



CITY: Pg 3

CM Gupta takes Metro, DTC bus under 'Metro Monday' campaign



NATION: Pg 5

President Murmu confers 66 Padma Awards



FILM: Pg 14

Was never in the race: Idris

ISSUES NOTICES ON PLEAS

‘Sad NTA has not learnt lessons’: SC raps agency over NEET paper leak

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: The Supreme Court on Monday expressed concern over the National Testing Agency's handling of the NEET examination, saying it was "sad" that the agency appeared not to have learned from the 2024 paper leak controversy, as it considered pleas seeking either a restructuring or replacement of the exam-conducting body.

“IT'S SAD THAT THEY HAVE NOT LEARNT THEIR LESSONS. THE MATTER TRAVELLED TO THIS COURT EARLIER ALSO”

A bench of Justices PS Narasimha and Alok Aradhya sought responses from the Centre, the National Testing Agency (NTA) and the Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI) on petitions calling for a more robust and autonomous mechanism to conduct the National Eligibility cum Entrance Test for undergraduate medical admissions.

“It's sad that they have not learnt their lessons.” Continued on P4

Petrol hits Rs 102 in Delhi after fourth hike in 11 days

Fuel prices at four-year high as cumulative hike reaches Rs 7.5 per litre

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Petrol and diesel prices rose again on Monday, the fourth time in less than two weeks, as state-run oil companies continued passing on the cost of higher global crude oil prices to consumers.

In Delhi, petrol now costs Rs 102.12 per litre, up from Rs 99.51, while diesel climbed to Rs 95.20 from Rs 92.49. Since May 15, the cumulative increase has reached nearly Rs 7.5 per litre across both fuels. Monday's revision alone added Rs 2.61 per litre to petrol and Rs 2.71 to diesel.

Prices are now at their highest since May 2022. They had



A worker fills fuel into a vehicle at a petrol pump PTI

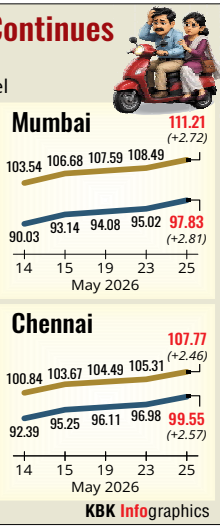
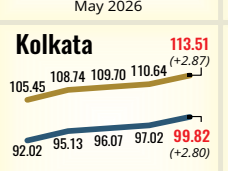
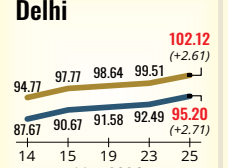
remained mostly unchanged for over two years, except for a Rs 2 per litre cut in March 2024, which came ahead of national elections.

The hikes have been phased in steps. Retail prices were first raised by Rs 3 per litre on May 15, followed by a 90-paise increase on

Fuel Price Hike Continues

Prices in ₹ per litre

Petrol Diesel



West Asia Conflict: Parliamentary panel told there is no immediate energy crisis

NEW DELHI: As tensions in West Asia continue to fuel concerns over global supply chains and energy security, the Centre on Monday assured a Parliamentary panel that

India remains prepared to deal with any disruption.

The assurance came during a nearly two-hour-long meeting of the Parliamentary Standing Com-

mittee on Transport, Tourism and Culture, which held discussions with senior officials from the Ministry of Ports, Shipping and Waterways on the evolving situation

Continued on P4

Heatwave tightens hold across India



Women cover themselves to shield from the scorching heat on a hot summer day, in Rishikesh, on Monday PTI

Uttar Pradesh's Banda, Maharashtra's Brahmapuri record 47.6 degrees Celsius

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: India reeled under an intense heatwave on Monday as temperatures surged across large parts of the country, with Uttar Pradesh's Banda and Maharashtra's Brahmapuri jointly recording the highest maximum temperature at 47.6 degrees Celsius, according to the India Meteorological Department (IMD). The weather agency warned that heatwave to severe heatwave conditions are likely to persist over central and north-west India for the next four to five days, while eastern and adjoining peninsular regions may continue to face similar conditions for the next three to four days. Relief is expected only from May 29, when temperatures are likely to begin falling.

The IMD classifies a heatwave in the plains when the maximum temperature

crosses 45 degrees Celsius, while temperatures above 47 degrees fall under the severe heatwave category.

In Uttar Pradesh, the start of the traditional nine-day summer spell known as Nau-tapa coincided with the sharp rise in temperatures. Banda emerged as one of the hot-

test places in the country at 47.6 degrees Celsius, which was 4.1 degrees above normal. Several other districts also recorded punishing daytime heat, with Jhansi at 46 degrees Celsius, Orai at 45.8 degrees, Agra at 45.5 degrees, Prayagraj at 45.4 degrees, and Hamirpur at 45.2 degrees.

Continued on P4

Don't take it sentimentally: SC declines urgent hearing on plea against Cockroach Janta Party

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: "Don't take it so sentimentally," the Supreme Court on Monday remarked while refusing to grant an urgent hearing on a plea seeking a probe into allegations regard-

ing fake advocates and activities associated with the Cockroach Janta Party (CJP), a satirical digital outfit that recently took social media by storm.

A bench of Chief Justice of India Surya Kant and Justice Joymalya Bagchi asked advo-

cate N K Goswami, appearing for the petitioner, not to take the issue "so sentimentally".

Goswami submitted that despite the CJJ's clarification, a distorted and malicious narrative was continuing.

Continued on P4

AIADMK suffers setback as 3 MLAs from rebel camp resign, set to join TVK

MPOST BUREAU

CHENNAI: In a new twist in the political arena in Tamil Nadu, three AIADMK MLAs met Tamil Nadu Assembly Speaker J C D Prabhakar on Monday to tender their resignations. The three belong to the rebel AIADMK group led by senior leaders C Ve Shanmugam and S P Velumani.

The three are set to join the ruling TVK, prompting "horse-trading" charges from the Opposition DMK and AIADMK.

AIADMK chief Edappadi K Palaniswami lashed out at the "fraud jobs" of the TVK government and said such things were new to Tamil

Nadu politics. He called the resignation episode a "pre-planned conspiracy."

The development comes weeks after the AIADMK lost the April 23 polls, the fourth major drubbing since 2019, its MLAs split into two groups, each supporting party general secretary Palaniswami and the Shanmugam-Velumani duo. The two camps took divergent positions on the TVK government's floor test, with the Palaniswami faction voting against it and the 25-member group on the other side backing the C Joseph Vijay-led government, which won the confidence vote.

Continued on P4

4 lakh FWICE members told not to work with Ranveer

MUMBAI: Federation of Western India Cine Employees on Monday barred its over four lakh members from working with Ranveer Singh over his last-minute exit from "Don 3", alleging losses exceed-

ing Rs 45 crore. Singh, through a spokesperson, said he chose silence amid speculation and continues to hold "deep respect and goodwill" for everyone linked to the franchise.

See P6

Trump says Iran talks progressing 'nicely'

WASHINGTON: The United States and Iran appear to be moving closer to an agreement to end the conflict and reopen the Strait of Hormuz, though key details remain unresolved. President Donald Trump said talks were "proceeding nicely" but warned fighting could restart if negotiations fail. Iranian Foreign Ministry spokesman Esmail Baghaei said understandings had been reached on "a large portion of the issues" but said no agreement was imminent. An Iranian delegation led by parliament speaker Mohammad Bagher Ghalibaf travelled to Qatar on Monday for talks. See P8

BIOMASS BURNING IS THE DOMINANT DRIVER 'PM pollution increased by 20% in Himalayan region, Indo-Gangetic Plain and North-East'

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: A new study has found that particulate matter pollution across the Indo-Gangetic Plain (IGP), the Himalayan region and North-East India rose by more than 20 per cent in 2010-2019 compared with the 2000-2009 baseline, pointing to a growing air quality burden across some of India's most sensitive regions.

The study, Decadal shifts in aerosol hotspots and source attribution over IGP, north-east India and Himalayas: A 25-year (2000-2024) study, was published in the journal Atmospheric Environment and released on Monday.

KEY POINTS

- » Study examined aerosol patterns over a 25-year period from 2000 to 2024
- » Findings published Monday in the journal Atmospheric Environment
- » Eastern Indo-Gangetic Plain showed rising carbonaceous aerosol trends throughout the study period

- » Crop residue, wood and organic material burning identified as major pollution sources
- » North-East India's pollution rise linked to slash-and-burn farming practices
- » Biomass use in rural households also contributed to North-East India's particulate surge

produced by the burning of crop residue, wood and other organic material.

"The eastern Indo-Gangetic Plain, and increasingly North-East

Continued on P4

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FAKES KIDNAPPING

Father kills 10-month-old daughter over cost of raising second girl child

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: A 25-year-old man allegedly drugged his family members and killed his 10-month-old daughter as he was unable to bear the financial burden of raising a second girl child, a police officer said on Monday.

The accused, identified as Deepak, strangled the infant, dumped her body in the septic tank of his house and fabricated a kidnapping story to mislead the police in Delhi's Bhalswa Dairy area, he said.

Her body was later recovered after Deepak confessed to his crime during interrogation.

Police said the accused had initially claimed that the child had gone missing from the house while stepping out to buy milk and biscuits on Saturday.

Deepak also told police that when he returned, he found his wife, Surya, and their elder daughter unconscious and his 10-month-old girl missing.

According to police, a call regarding the alleged kidnap-



ping was received on May 24.

A massive search operation due to the sensitive nature of the case was launched. Multiple police teams were formed immediately, and CCTV footage around the locality was scanned to trace the infant and identify possible suspects," Deputy Commissioner of Police (Outer North district) Hareshwar Swami said in a statement.

During the probe, investigators found glaring inconsistencies in Deepak's version of events. A detailed analysis of

CCTV footage failed to support his claim that he had gone outside when the child was kidnapped, Swami said.

Additionally, Deepak's father had said that when his son returned home, he could not find the infant.

"We then called people from the neighbourhood and started searching for her, but we could not find her. We informed the police, and a massive hunt was launched," Deepak's father said.

During questioning, Deepak allegedly confessed that he was under financial distress and

CLOSER LOOK

» 'A massive search op due to the sensitive nature of the case was launched. Multiple police teams were formed immediately, and CCTV footage around the locality was scanned to trace the infant and identify possible suspects'

» Investigators found glaring inconsistencies in Deepak's version of events. A detailed analysis of CCTV footage failed to support his claim: Police

Police subsequently added Section 103(1) (murder) of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita to the case and arrested the accused.

Police said Deepak, a resident of Mukundpur in Bhalswa Dairy, had studied till class 12 and worked as a school van driver for a private school.

Another police officer said investigators are also examining whether any other family members had prior knowledge of the crime or helped Deepak conceal evidence. Statements of family members and neighbours are being recorded as part of the probe.

"We are also probing the drug angle in the matter, as the family had claimed that they were unconscious. Teams are working on multiple angles," the officer said. Meanwhile, locals raised suspicions about the family members.

Residents said locals and police searched extensively for the toddler before the father allegedly confessed to killing the child.

'Watchman's hit-and-run murder could be planned'

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The killing of a 60-year-old watchman by a car driver in Outer Delhi's Peeragarhi village appears to be "more planned than spontaneous", police said on Monday. The culprit fled in the SUV with no number plate after repeatedly running over the man, making identification difficult, they said.

The police said investigators are probing attempted theft, previous enmity and a dispute linked to the tempo stand where the victim worked.

CCTV footage has captured the movement of the SUV, which was last seen near Hiran Kudna on the Delhi-Haryana border, he said.

The victim, Bijender Bhardwaj, worked as a watchman at a tempo stand in Peeragarhi village. He was alone at the spot when he was attacked around 2.54 am on Sunday, according to the CCTV footage.

"The man was first beaten with sticks and then run over three to four times by the SUV," an officer said. According to investigators, footage shows an SUV parked near the tempo stand with its headlights on



while Bhardwaj sat on a chair.

A man is later seen stepping out carrying a stick and attacking him. As Bhardwaj tries to flee, the man gets behind the wheel, knocks him down, and runs him over a few times before driving away.

The police said the absence of a registration number plate on the SUV has emerged as a major challenge in tracing the driver. "While all angles are being probed, the murder appears more planned than spontaneous, unlike a typical road rage case," the officer said. "There is a possibility of previous enmity or that the deceased may have objected to theft or suspicious activity in the area, following which the accused took revenge."

Speaking to reporters, Mukesh Bhardwaj, the younger brother of the deceased, alleged

that the attackers deliberately targeted him while he was on duty.

"He was sitting peacefully on his chair when a man got out of the car and beat him with sticks. Then the SUV reversed and rammed into him from three sides," he said.

"Around 3 am, we received a call from another chowkidar informing us about the incident. He was alone there at that time. There was no past enmity with anyone. Maybe there had been some argument earlier. They might have tried to steal something, and my brother may have stopped them," he added.

Family members also alleged lapses in the initial police response.

The victim's granddaughter claimed that police at first treated the matter as a road accident despite the family insisting it was murder.

"We told the police from the beginning that it was murder, but they first registered it as an accident case. Later, murder charges were added. They (accused) had planned the whole thing. My grandfather had been working there for nearly a year," she alleged.

Police stress respect, consent at NCC gender sensitisation event

PRAJYOT DEOGHARE

NEW DELHI: Around 700 NCC cadets attended a gender sensitisation programme organised by the Self Defence Wing of the Special Police Unit for Women and Children (SPUWAC) at the DG NCC Parade Ground in Delhi Cantonment, with officials emphasising the importance of gender equality, women's safety and responsible social behaviour among young people.

The programme was conducted under the supervision of DCP/SPUWAC Neha Yadav as part of the Delhi Police's ongoing efforts to promote awareness and encourage youth participation in building a safer and more inclusive society.

Officials said the initiative aimed to sensitise male cadets on issues related to respect for women, prevention of harassment and the need for appropriate conduct in both public and private spaces.

During the interactive ses-

Programme held under supervision of DCP/SPUWAC Neha Yadav

sion, officers and trainers from the Self Defence Wing engaged with the cadets on various aspects of gender sensitivity and social responsibility.

Participants were educated on the importance of treating women with dignity and respect, understanding consent, and discouraging behaviour that could lead to harassment or discrimination.

Officers also highlighted the role young people can play in shaping social attitudes and creating an environment where women feel safe and empowered. Cadets were encouraged to act responsibly in their daily lives and become ambassadors of gender equality within their communities and institutions.

According to officials, the

programme witnessed enthusiastic participation, with many cadets actively interacting with trainers and sharing their views during the session.

SPUWAC officials said such awareness programmes are regularly organised across educational institutions and youth platforms to strengthen public understanding of gender-related issues and promote social harmony.

The Self Defence Wing has been conducting outreach activities aimed at empowering citizens, particularly students and young people, through awareness campaigns, sensitisation drives and self-defence initiatives.

Police officials reiterated that continued engagement with youth is essential for fostering a culture of mutual respect, equality and responsible citizenship, adding that similar programmes would continue as part of SPUWAC's community outreach efforts.

Student dies after accidentally shooting himself at party

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: A 21-year-old student died of a gunshot wound he accidentally inflicted on himself in North Delhi's Rohini, police said on Monday.

Raja, a local, died on Sunday at a party in Jain Nagar, they said.

By the time the police reached the spot, the man had been taken by his friend to a local hospital. A critical Raja succumbed at the hospital.

An empty cartridge was recovered from the spot, an officer said.

According to an initial investigation, a group of friends had gathered for a party where Raja sustained a gunshot injury in his stomach after he accidentally fired the weapon.

"The injured person had given his recorded statement in which he stated that the



bullet was fired accidentally by him and struck his stomach," the officer said.

The police suspect that the firearm belonged to one of Raja's friends who was at the party. However, the exact ownership of the weapon and whether it was licensed or illegal are being verified, the officer said.

After the incident, Raja's friends allegedly fled from the spot. The police have registered a case and are probing all likely angles.

Minors apprehended from Haridwar for stabbing factory owner in Capital

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Delhi Police has apprehended two juveniles for allegedly stabbing a man inside his factory in Shahdara's Gandhi Nagar over a monetary dispute, an official said on Monday.

The minors were apprehended from Haridwar in Uttarakhand after they allegedly attacking the factory owner and fleeing Delhi, he said.

The incident took place on May 21 in the Dharampura area of Gandhi Nagar. A PCR call regarding a stabbing incident was received at Gandhi Nagar police station following which police teams rushed to the spot. During preliminary inquiry, police found that around 12.30 pm, the two juveniles had gone to the complainant's factory in Dharampura where an argu-



Around 12.30 pm, 2 minors had gone to complainant's factory where an argument broke out over a monetary dispute: Police

ment broke out over a monetary dispute. The altercation soon turned violent and the accused allegedly attacked the victim with a sharp object before fleeing, police said.

The injured man was rushed to Jag Parvash Hospital by his wife, who also informed the police about the incident.

Based on the victim's statement, an FIR under relevant sections of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita (BNS) pertaining to attempt to murder was registered at Gandhi Nagar police station and investigation was initiated.

Police analysed technical evidence and gathered local intelligence, which revealed that the suspects had escaped to Haridwar, officials said.

A police team reached Haridwar and conducted surveillance near Har Ki Pauri area, where both juveniles were identified and apprehended, officials said. They were later brought to Delhi for further legal proceedings.

During sustained interrogation, both juveniles allegedly admitted to their involvement in the attack, police said, adding that further investigation is underway.

SOL students allege unequal treatment at DU

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Students associated with the School of Open Learning (SOL), University of Delhi, have alleged unequal treatment in comparison to regular college students, raising concerns over delays in academic processes and limited access to institutional facilities.

According to student representatives, learners enrolled in the open learning system frequently face delays in examination schedules and declaration of results. They also claimed that study material is often not provided on time, affecting academic preparation for a large number of students enrolled in undergraduate and postgraduate programmes.

The students further alleged that SOL candidates do not receive equal access to facilities such as libraries, counselling services, placement support, and other academic resources available to regular college students. Concerns were also raised regarding confusion during admission procedures and examination-related processes, which students said creates unnecessary stress and uncertainty.

Student groups urged Delhi University to ensure equal treatment and timely support for over four lakh SOL students, saying the institution plays a vital role in expanding access to higher education for diverse socio-economic groups, including working professionals and non-regular learners.

SFI-JMI criticises Jamia admin over event associated with RSS

ANAMTA FATIMA

NEW DELHI: The Students' Federation of India (SFI), Jamia Millia Islamia unit, on criticised the university administration for allegedly facilitating an event linked to organisations associated with the Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh (RSS). The student body objected to the installation of a "welcome gate" for the Janjati Sanskritik Samagam programme, which it claimed was connected to the Janjati Suraksha Manch.

The student organisation alleged that the event represented a broader political agenda rather than a neutral cultural programme. It stated that Jamia Millia Islamia has historically stood for secular-

ism, democracy, and anti-colonial values, and argued that the administration's support for the event contradicted the university's inclusive character.

SFI-JMI further claimed that while student protests and democratic gatherings on campus often face restrictions, the administration appeared more accommodating towards organisations linked to the RSS ecosystem.

The statement described this as "ironic" and accused the authorities of selectively allowing political activities on campus.

The student body also raised concerns regarding the condition of Adivasi communities across the country. Referring to issues such as forest rights, land

acquisition, and mining projects in States including Chhattisgarh and Odisha, it alleged that tribal populations were being displaced in the name of development. The organisation questioned what it described as the "tokenistic celebration" of Adivasi culture without addressing larger socio-economic concerns related to land, forests, and livelihoods.

SFI-JMI demanded that the university administration clarify its role in facilitating the event and ensure that the institution's spaces are not used to legitimise what it termed "communal and partisan politics." The organisation also called for the protection of Jamia's democratic and secular environment.

STAFF FEAR LOSS OF LIVELIHOODS AS UNCERTAINTY GRIPS THE CENTURY-OLD INSTITUTION

Gymkhana Club seeks halt on takeover, assures staff on jobs

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The general committee overseeing the Delhi Gymkhana Club on Monday urged the Centre not to disrupt the functioning of the institution until clarity emerges on issues including its proposed relocation and protection of employees, amid growing uncertainty over the future of the century-old club after the government directed it to vacate its premises in Lutyens' Delhi by June 5.

In a letter sent to the Land and Development Office (L&DO), the committee con-

stituted by the Government of India requested the Ministry of Housing and Urban Affairs and the L&DO to consider allotting an alternative plot for relocation in case the takeover proceeds.

The committee said the interests of members, employees and other stakeholders should be protected before any decision affecting the club's operations is implemented. It also sought safeguards for nearly 600 employees associated with the institution.

The L&DO, under the Union Housing and Urban Affairs Ministry, had directed



the club to hand over its 27.3-acre Safdarjung Road premises, stating that the land was required for "urgent institutional needs, governance infrastructure and public interest project", including strengthening defence-related infrastructure.

Meanwhile, club man-

The club management assured concerned employees on Monday that their jobs were secure

agement assured concerned employees on Monday that their jobs were secure and that the club would not shut down immediately, amid rising anxiety among staff members who said they had received little formal communication regarding salaries, relocation plans or future employment.

On Monday morning, a group of employees gathered at a small shrine dedicated to 'Pir Baba' near the club premises and prayed for a favourable outcome as uncertainty over livelihoods deepened inside the institution.

Soon afterwards, staff members said they were informed by members of the general committee that legal and administrative efforts were underway to protect employee interests.

"We received a call from club president Malay Sinha and director Kuldeep Chahal during the day. They assured

us that our concerns had been conveyed to the government through a special written note and that discussions were underway," Nandan Singh Negi, president of the Gymkhana Employee Welfare Association, said.

Negi added that the management had assured employees that the club would not close on June 5 and that their jobs were secure.

Employees expressed panic over job uncertainty and possible legal action, while members defended the club's heritage value and cited administrative and financial improvements.

IGIA Customs seize 17.7 kg hydroponic weed

NEW DELHI: Customs officials at Delhi's IGI Airport have booked a drug smuggling case after seizing 17.720 kg of suspected hydroponic weed from the baggage of an international passenger, officials said on Monday. A passenger arriving from Bangkok on May 12 was kept under surveillance, while another arriving from Sharjah was intercepted during profiling. During examination, customs officials recovered baggage tags and seized the contraband concealed inside a bag.

CM Gupta takes Metro, DTC bus under 'Metro Monday' campaign

Min Sirsa inspects Okhla CETPs as city intensifies Yamuna rejuvenation efforts

Delhi govt hospitals secure national quality certification

Chaos in MCD House after AAP councillors raise NEET leak issue & target Central govt

GREATER NOIDA: A 32-year-old man was found hanging in a park and a 35-year-old transgender person was found dead with head injuries in separate incidents in Greater Noida, police said on Monday. Police said Shivam, a native of Mahoba working at an electric shop, was found dead in a park under the Knowledge Park police station area. In another case, Manoranjan Sharma alias Chandini was found dead in a rented room in Tugalpur village. MPOST

MCD launches drive against illegal dairies & stray cattle

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MININGS IN ARAVALLI

Expert committee on Aravalli must consult domain experts, other stakeholders: SC

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The Supreme Court on Monday said the expert committee to be constituted to define the Aravalli hills and ranges must consult domain experts and other stakeholders so that the public is heard at large.

A bench comprising Chief Justice Surya Kant and Justices Joymalya Bagchi and Vipul M Pancholi also said the committee cannot have a large composition as it becomes unmanageable.

“We cannot have a composition of 30 people as it will become unmanageable. The committee must consult experts, and it should have 5-7 members. We will note it in the order,” the bench said.

As the hearing commenced, Additional Solicitor General Aishwarya Bhati, appearing for the Cen-



tre, submitted that the Central Empowered Committee and the amicus curiae have given common names to be included (in the panel), which can be finalised.

Senior advocate K Parameshwar, the amicus curiae, said the expert committee must take into account the stakeholders as well so that the public is heard at large.

The top court had earlier asked the environment ministry and other stakeholders

to suggest names of domain experts for the panel, which would define the Aravalli hills and ranges, the world's oldest mountain system.

On December 29 last year, the top court took note of the outcry over the new definition of the Aravallis and kept in abeyance its November 20 directions that accepted a uniform definition of these hills and ranges.

It had also stalled all mining activities in the Aravallis. The apex court said there

Highlights

» A bench comprising Chief Justice Surya Kant also said the committee cannot have a large composition as it becomes unmanageable

» The top court had earlier asked the environment ministry and other stakeholders to suggest names of domain experts for the panel, which would define the Aravalli hills and ranges

was a need to resolve “critical ambiguities”, including whether the criteria of 100-metre elevation and the 500-metre gap between hills would strip a significant portion of the range of environmental protection.

On November 20, 2025, the top court accepted a uniform definition of the Aravalli hills and ranges and banned the grant of fresh mining leases inside its areas spanning Delhi, Haryana, Rajasthan and Gujarat until experts’ reports are out.

It had accepted the recommendations of a committee of the Ministry of Environment, Forest and Climate Change on the definition of the Aravalli hills and ranges to protect them.

The committee had recommended that the “Aravalli Hill” be defined as any landform in designated Aravalli districts with an elevation of 100 metres or more above its local relief, and an “Aravalli Range” will be a collection of two or more such hills within 500 metres of each other.

Employees of aided, unaided institutes not liable for Census task: Allahabad HC

OUR CORRESPONDENT



Allahabad High Court

‘This Court prima facie finds that the teaching and non-teaching staff of private institutions, whether aided or unaided, cannot be said to fall within the purview of ‘local authorities’

“Further, in view of the list forwarded by the B.S.A. to the Charge Officer pursuant to his letter dated April 8, 2026, the employees of aided and unaided institutions cannot be made liable for any task under

the Census Act, 1948,” added the court.

The court was hearing a petition filed by ‘Independent Self Financed Schools Association’ whereby an order of the DIOS, by which it directed the principal/management of all aided and unaided institutions to provide a list of all teaching and non-teaching staff for Census duty, was challenged.

According to the petitioner, the staff of teaching institutions was not covered under ‘Local Authority’ under Section 4A of the Census Act, 1948 which provides that every local authority that has been so directed must provide staff for the Census duty.

It was further argued that private institutions would not fall under the ambit of local authority as they were neither controlled by the government nor were their subsidiaries.

The court passed the order on May 21 which came into the limelight on Monday.

From Page 1

Petrol hits

May 19, and another round on May 23 when petrol went up by 87 paise and diesel by 91 paise per litre.

Prices differ across cities because of state taxes. After Monday’s revision, petrol in Mumbai stands at Rs 111.21 per litre and diesel at Rs 97.83. In Kolkata, petrol costs Rs 113.51 and diesel Rs 99.82. Chennai residents are paying Rs 107.77 for petrol and Rs 99.55 for diesel.

Global crude oil prices rose more than 50 per cent from late February after US-Israeli strikes on Iran disrupted shipping through the Strait of Hormuz, a major oil transit route. State-run retailers had held back passing on those higher costs for several weeks.

On Monday, however, crude prices fell sharply after the United States and Iran agreed in principle to reopen the Strait of Hormuz, with Brent crude dropping more than 5 per cent.

The three state-owned fuel retailers, Indian Oil Corporation, Bharat Petroleum and Hindustan Petroleum, together control about 90 per cent of India’s fuel market. Despite the price increases, petrol, diesel and domestic cooking gas LPG are still being sold at a loss. Jet fuel rates have been kept on hold.

Sujata Sharma, Joint Secretary in the Ministry of Petroleum and Natural Gas, said losses were running close to Rs 600 crore per day, down from Rs 1,000 crore before May 15.

Since mid-May, domestic LPG prices have also gone up by Rs 60 per 14.2-kg cylinder, and compressed natural gas by Rs 4 per kg.

Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman, speaking in Mumbai, said the revision was a market-driven decision by oil marketing companies. She said the government had already contributed by forgoing over Rs 1 lakh crore annually in tax revenues through excise duty cuts of Rs 10 per litre on petrol and diesel.

Private retailers have also revised prices. Nayara Energy raised petrol and diesel prices by Rs 5 and Rs 3 per litre respectively in March. Shell raised petrol prices by Rs 7.41 and diesel by as much as Rs 25 per litre from April 1. Jio-bp aligned its pump prices with state-run firms.

Congress leader Rahul Gandhi criticised the timing of the increases, saying prices were being raised in instalments after state elections concluded. “Petrol and diesel prices are being increased in instalments so that people’s pockets are quietly picked,” he wrote on social media.

Congress president Mallikarjun Kharge alleged the government had collected Rs 43 lakh crore over 12 years as petrol prices rose from Rs 71.41 per litre in 2014 to Rs 102.12 today, and diesel from Rs 56.71 to Rs 95.20.

The first increase on May 15 came days after the BJP won three of five state and union territory elections, including West Bengal.

India’s retail inflation stood at 3.48 per cent in April, up from 3.40 per cent in March. Wholesale inflation rose to an over three-year high of 8.3 per cent, driven by fuel and energy costs. The fuel hikes are expected to push up transportation

and logistics costs further.

Prime Minister Narendra Modi last week called on citizens and government departments to conserve fuel, consider remote working and cut non-essential travel, as higher energy prices strain foreign exchange reserves and risk widening the current account deficit. Several state governments have already asked departments to reduce travel and office attendance.

West Asia Conflict:

arising out of the West Asia crisis.

Several members of the parliamentary panel grilled officials of the Oil ministry over “long queues” and “rationing” of petrol and diesel at petrol pumps in some parts of the country, and were informed by the officials that the country had crude oil stocks for the next 78 days, sources said.

Officials told the committee that despite growing instability in the region, there is “no immediate crisis” relating to energy supplies or fertiliser availability in the country.

The officials told the Parliamentary Standing Committee on Transport, Tourism and Culture, which met to discuss the impact of the West Asia crisis on maritime trade, that 13 Indian ships continued to be stranded in West Asia due to the closure of the Strait of Hormuz, they said.

The government has made efforts to ensure there is no shortage. However, the uncertainty on when the war would end continues, the officials told the panel.

Some opposition MPs also sought to know why corrective measures were not taken in advance, knowing that the West Asia war would not end soon. Some members told the officials that they should have planned in advance to mitigate the suffering of common people due to high oil and fertiliser prices.

The officials of the Shipping Ministry informed the Parliamentary Committee that as many as 37 Indian ships were stranded in West Asia in March and 13 are still stuck due to the closure of the Strait of Hormuz, amid uncertainty over the end of the war, the sources said.

The Fertiliser Ministry officials are also learnt to have informed the parliamentary panel members that there is no shortage of fertilisers in the country ahead of the Kharif sowing and the government has made alternative arrangements.

The sources said that when some opposition members raised the issue of high global prices of fertilisers, the officials informed the panel that the government has procured around 80 lakh tonnes of fertilisers from alternative sources.

At present, the demand is to the tune of 78 lakh tonnes of fertilisers, which was being met, the sources added.

India’s maritime trade, especially in the energy sector, has been hit after the West Asia war broke out on February 28, disrupting ship movement in the Strait of Hormuz. A large portion of India’s fuel supplies came from the Gulf and West Asian countries.

Representatives from the Ministry of External Affairs, the

Ministry of Commerce and the Petroleum Ministry also attended the meeting and briefed the panel on contingency measures being taken by the government to safeguard India’s economic and strategic interests. MPOST

NEET paper leak

The matter travelled to this court earlier also. There was a committee, a monitoring committee which made some recommendations, and they were accepted. We want the NTA to file an affidavit on the steps taken for compliance of recommendations suggested by the committee,” the bench said.

The court directed that copies of the petitions be served on Solicitor General Tushar Mehta and other parties. It also asked the NTA to submit an affidavit by Thursday detailing compliance with directions issued by the apex court last year.

The bench said all similar petitions would be heard together, including one filed by the Federation of All India Medical Association (FAIMA) through advocate Tanvi Dubey. The matter has been listed for further hearing on Friday, with all parties asked to submit their responses within three days.

The court also asked the Centre-appointed committee led by former ISRO chief K Radhakrishnan, which was tasked with reviewing the functioning of the NTA, to provide details of steps taken in line with earlier judicial directions.

FAIMA has sought either direct restructuring of the NTA or its replacement with an independent body to oversee NEET-UG, arguing that repeated paper leaks have harmed the rights of more than 22 lakh students. The petition described the issue as a “direct assault” on constitutional guarantees under Articles 14 and 21.

The organisation has also requested the appointment of an interim high-powered monitoring committee to supervise a re-examination until a new system is established. It proposed that such a panel be headed by a retired Supreme Court judge and include a cybersecurity expert and a forensic scientist.

NEET-UG 2026, conducted on May 3 for medical admissions, was cancelled on May 12 following allegations of a paper leak. The CBI is investigating the matter.

According to the FAIMA petition, Rajasthan Police’s Special Operations Group found that “guess papers” circulated on WhatsApp and Telegram matched 120 questions from the actual Biology and Chemistry sections of the examination.

The petition alleged that despite the NTA’s claims of security arrangements such as 5G jammers, GPS tracking and AI-monitored cameras, these safeguards existed “only on paper”.

It also asked the Supreme Court to direct the CBI to submit a status report within four weeks detailing the leak network, arrests, charges and prosecution progress. For greater transparency, it urged publication of centre-wise NEET-UG 2026 results when available.

Referring to the 2024 controversy, the petition said the NTA continued to rely on vulnerable methods such as physical printing of papers and transportation through private couriers. It

also cited earlier judicial observations about unauthorised access to strongrooms and the transport of sensitive exam material via e-rickshaws and private couriers.

The cancellation has left over 22 lakh aspirants and their families waiting for clarity on the fresh exam date, admit cards, centres and counselling schedule.

Gondola crisis

request from the Cable Car Corporation and the Baramulla district administration.

“Information about the malfunction was received around 12:45 pm to 1 pm. We were informed that a technical fault had developed in the gondola system after the gearbox malfunctioned,” Joshi said.

He said rescue teams faced significant challenges because of rain and hailstorms, but operations continued with coordinated efforts from multiple agencies. The Indian Army, including personnel from the High Altitude Warfare School and Chinara Corps, joined teams from the National Disaster Response Force (NDRF), State Disaster Response Force (SDRF), Jammu and Kashmir Police, and district authorities.

Rescue personnel used ropes, ladders, and technical extraction methods to evacuate stranded passengers cabin by cabin. The Army also deployed Casualty Assistance Teams between the Gondola Base Station and Phase 1, along with an all-terrain vehicle to support evacuation in the rough terrain. Additional ATVs were arranged through the Gulmarg ATV Association.

By late afternoon, 179 tourists had been rescued. As the operation progressed, officials said 22 cable cars were evacuated from the base side, taking the number of rescued people to 286 by early evening. The remaining passengers were brought down in later phases, with officials confirming by night that the rescue mission had been completed successfully.

“The rescue operation has concluded, and all the stranded persons have been evacuated safely,” an official said.

Authorities said all cabins remained stable throughout the incident and no injuries were reported. Stranded tourists were kept informed through public address systems and megaphones to prevent panic. Tea, refreshments, and basic assistance were arranged at the base station for those rescued.

Chief Minister Omar Abdullah said the government closely monitored the situation while the rescue operation was underway. “All cabins are intact and rescue operations to safely evacuate stranded tourists are underway with trained teams on the ground. The situation is completely under control and there is no cause for panic,” he said in a post on X.

Later, the Chief Minister’s Office said an investigation would be conducted into the malfunction.

“The incident will be thoroughly examined and an enquiry conducted. Responsibility for any lapses will be fixed and appropriate action taken,” the office said, while also praising the agencies involved in the rescue.

Lieutenant Governor Manoj Sinha said he personally moni-

tored the operation and had directed Director General of Police Nalin Prabhat to proceed to Gulmarg to oversee the rescue efforts. Deputy Chief Minister Surinder Kumar Choudhary, along with local MLA Farooq Ahmed Shah and senior officials, also visited the site.

The Gulmarg Gondola has witnessed technical interruptions in the past, including a temporary suspension in January last year. A fatal accident in June 2017 claimed seven lives when a cabin crashed after an uprooted tree struck the ropeway during strong winds.

Cockroach Janta Party

“Don’t take it so sentimentally,” the CJI said.

Another advocate submitted that they were seeking a CBI probe into the issue of fake law degrees and said courtroom exchanges cannot be used for commercial purposes.

The CJI replied, “There is no such grave urgency. We will see.”

The petition has also sought action against those involved in the alleged commercial exploitation of oral observations made during court proceedings. It sought an investigation into alleged fake advocates practising law using fraudulent degrees.

Expressing concern over the misuse of judicial proceedings, the plea claimed that remarks and observations made during the court proceedings were being used for publicity campaigns.

The CJP surfaced recently amid a controversy over remarks attributed to CJI Surya Kant on “cockroaches” and “parasites” during a court hearing on May 15 on a plea concerning senior designation for a lawyer.

On May 16, the CJI issued a strongly worded clarification of his remarks, saying he was “pained” by media reports suggesting he had criticised the youth.

He had emphasised that his remarks were specifically directed at individuals entering the legal profession through “fake and bogus degrees” and were “misquoted by a section of the media”.

Heatwave

Lucknow recorded a maximum of 42.3 degrees Celsius and a minimum of 28.6 degrees Celsius.

The IMD said eastern Uttar Pradesh is likely to witness heatwave to severe heatwave conditions at isolated places, while western parts of the state may also experience heatwave conditions during the daytime. Warm nights are also expected in both regions.

The Uttar Pradesh government has issued public advisories asking residents to avoid going outdoors between noon and 4 pm unless necessary, wear light clothing, and remain hydrated through fluids and seasonal fruits. Hospitals and health centres across the state have also been placed on alert.

Authorities in some districts adopted unusual measures to manage the extreme weather.

In Lucknow’s Hazratganj, green shade cloths were installed above

traffic signals to shield commuters, while water mist was sprayed at intersections to bring down surrounding temperatures.

In Gonda, power department workers tried to prevent transformers from overheating amid rising electricity demand. “We are repeating the cooling process every half an hour so that the transformer does not overheat and break down in this extreme heat,” an electricity department worker said.

In Maharashtra, the Vidarbha region remained under severe heat stress. Brahmapuri again recorded 47.6 degrees Celsius, about five degrees above normal. Nagpur registered 46.5 degrees Celsius, while Gadchiroli and Bhandara both recorded 46.4 degrees. Gondia touched 46.1 degrees, and Akola recorded 45.4 degrees. The IMD has issued a heatwave alert for the region for two days, followed by an orange alert until May 28.

Rajasthan also remained in the grip of severe heat. Kota was the hottest in the state at 45.6 degrees Celsius. Chittorgarh and Sriganganagar recorded 45 degrees each, while Pilani reached 44.5 degrees. Alwar recorded 44.4 degrees, Jaipur 44.3 degrees, and Bikaner 44.2 degrees.

In Haryana, Sirsa recorded 46.2 degrees Celsius, followed by Rohtak at 45.2 degrees.

Madhya Pradesh’s Khajuraho registered 47.2 degrees Celsius, making it one of the hottest locations in the country.

Delhi also saw scorching conditions, with the Ridge weather station recording a maximum temperature of 44.3 degrees Celsius.

Even daily life adapted to the harsh weather. In Varanasi, children attending a swimming camp on the Ganga sought some relief from the heat, while in Ayodhya, priests and devotees observed rituals associated with Nautapa.

Pawan Das Shastri, general secretary of the Ayodhya Sant Samiti, said, “When the Sun enters the Rohini constellation during the month of Jyeshtha, the following nine days are called Nautapa.”

The IMD said temperatures are likely to remain largely unchanged over the next three days before a significant drop of 6 to 8 degrees Celsius later in the week.

AIADMK

With Speaker Prabhakar accepting the resignation of the three MLAs, the strength of the AIADMK has dropped to 44 from 47 in the 234-member Assembly. The Speaker said the EC will be informed of the resignation.

The three legislators—Maragatham Kumaravel, P Sathyabama and S Jayakumar, met senior TVK leader and PWD minister Aadhar Arjuna. Kumaravel said “we are going to join TVK in Panayur (party hq),” later in the day.

Meanwhile, five MLAs from the Shanmugam-Velumani camp went back to party chief Palaniswami. When reporters sought his response over the developments, Shanmugam only said, “We will talk later.”

The three AIADMK MLAs called on the Speaker at the Secretariat here and submitted their resignations. Dharapuram (Tiruppur) and Perundurai (Erode)

are part of AIADMK’s traditional stronghold, the ‘Kongu’ region in western Tamil Nadu. Madurantakam is located near Chennai.

The three were among the 25 legislators who voted in support of the C Joseph Vijay-led TVK government during the May 13 floor test, defying the party diktat.

Meanwhile, the five AIADMK MLAs who had been in the Shanmugam-Velumani camp, shifted their allegiance back to party chief Palaniswami. With this, the number of Palaniswami-supporting MLAs in the Assembly has risen to 27. The legislators who left the Velumani camp included S M Sukumar (Arcot).

With three resignations and five MLAs going back to the Palaniswami camp, the strength of the rebel side has now reduced to 17, from 25.

With the Speaker accepting the resignations, Tamil Nadu will witness byelections to four Assembly constituencies, including the Tiruchirappalli East vacated by Vijay.

Speaker Prabhakar told reporters that the three AIADMK MLAs’ resignation was accepted since they were in proper format, as per laid down procedures. “There is no need to mention the reason to step down,” he said in a response to a question.

The resignation and split in the AIADMK has come within 21 days of declaration of Assembly election results. Post poll, this is a major jolt for the AIADMK. The DMK too has suffered a setback with its allies the Congress, VCK and IUML joining the TVK government and the Left parties extending their support to the Vijay-led dispensation.

WITH AGENCY INPUTS

PM pollution

India, are carrying a disproportionate pollution burden and it is being driven almost entirely by biomass burning. That is the signal that stands out most clearly across 25 years of data,” said Abhijit Chatterjee, co-author of the study and professor at the Bose Institute in Kolkata.

The study said the sharp increase in particulate matter levels in North-East India was linked to intensified slash-and-burn farming practices and widespread use of biomass as household fuel in rural areas during the study period. Researchers also found that pollution generated in the Indo-Gangetic Plain does not remain confined to the source regions but travels into the Himalayas.

According to the analysis, emissions from Punjab and Delhi affect the western Himalayan ranges, while pollution originating in Bihar and West Bengal reaches the eastern Himalayas.

“Our trajectory analysis shows that what is emitted in Punjab or Bihar does not stay there. It travels into the mountains. These are ecologically and climatically sensitive zones, and they are currently outside the scope of any structured clean air intervention in India,” said Soumen Raul, senior research fellow at the Bose Institute.

The findings point to a widening regional air pollution challenge, with biomass burning emerging as a major contributor across multiple geographies over the 25-year study period.

Centre slammed over fuel price hike

‘Mehangai manav’ strikes again: Congress attacks Prime Minister Modi over fresh hike

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Various Opposition parties attack BJP-led Centre over the latest fuel price hike which was the fourth increase within the span of two weeks.

The Congress on Monday launched a scathing attack on Prime Minister Narendra Modi over the latest hike, with Rahul Gandhi alleging that the “mehangai manav” has struck again and he has just one job of making promises during elections and attacking people’s pockets at other times.

Congress president Mallikarjun Kharge also lashed out at the Modi government over the issue and asked who is benefitting from this “daily robbery”.

Petrol and diesel prices were raised by Rs 2.61-2.71 per litre on Monday, marking the fourth increase in less than two weeks as state-owned fuel retailers continued to pass on rising international oil prices to consumers.

In a post in Hindi on



Consumers wait at a petrol station amid multiple hikes in fuel prices, in Patna

X, Gandhi said, “Mehangai manav Modi strikes again. He raises petrol and diesel prices in installments - ensuring that your pockets are quietly picked.”

“For months, I had been warning of an impending economic storm. But Modi Ji, true to form, was busy with elections at the time and the moment the elections ended, he hiked the prices of petrol and diesel by Rs 8,” the leader of opposition in the Lok Sabha

said.

Congress president Kharge alleged that the Modi government has looted Rs 43 lakh crore in the last 12 years.

“The Daily Assault of FUEL LOOT is not over yet! 4th hike in 10 days!! Petrol Rs 7.35/litre, Diesel Rs 7.53/litre. The Modi government has sprinkled petrol to burn the savings of common people,” he said in a post on X.

The Opposition NCP (SP) on Monday targeted the Cen-

tre over skyrocketing petrol and diesel prices, alleging that the common public was being “economically exploited” while international crude benefits were withheld.

After petrol and diesel prices were increased for the fourth time, AAP national convenor Arvind Kejriwal questioned Prime Minister Narendra Modi over the Centre not buying fuel from Russia and Iran.

“Oil prices have risen again.

Highlights

- » Kharge alleged that the Modi government has looted Rs 43 lakh crore in the last 12 years
- » Kejriwal questioned PM Modi over the Centre not buying cheap fuel from Russia and Iran
- » NCP (SP) alleges common public was being “economically exploited”

Russia and Iran are offering us cheaper and sufficient oil and gas. Why is Prime Minister Narendra Modi not buying cheap oil from them?” Kejriwal said in a video message on X.

Political parties in Punjab and Haryana on Monday launched a scathing attack on the BJP-led Centre over the fresh hike in fuel prices, calling it a crippling blow to ordinary citizens already grappling with rising prices of essential commodities.

CBSE MARKING ROW

Oppn alleges govt intimidates anyone who asks questions

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: As the row over CBSE’s On-Screen Marking (OSM) system escalates, Congress leader Rahul Gandhi on Monday alleged that the “Modi-Pradhan duo” has turned yet another institution into a “symbol of malpractice” and accused the government of defaming and intimidating anyone who asks questions.

AAP convenor Arvind Kejriwal also attacked the Centre over the issue, calling Union Education minister Dharmendra Pradhan “incompetent and useless”. He also demanded Pradhan’s resignation over the alleged irregularities in the OSM system.

The Opposition leaders’ remarks came after some Class 12 students alleged that the scanned copies of their answer sheets uploaded by the board did not match their handwriting, raising concerns over possible answer-sheet mismatch in the OSM system.

CBSE sources said the

The Pointers

- » CBSE sources said the board is treating all complaints on top priority
- » Kejriwal demanded Pradhan’s resignation over alleged irregularities in OSM system

board is treating all complaints on top priority.

In a detailed post on social media, a Delhi-based student identified as Vedant alleged that the Physics answer sheet uploaded by the CBSE under the re-evaluation process was not his own.

The Vedant’s post, which garnered over 2.5 million views on X, said he and his family discovered that the handwriting in the Physics answer sheet provided by CBSE did not match his own.

Several social media handles, however, initially trolled him, questioning whether the

newly-created handle was actually of a CSBE student, with some even calling him “anti-national” and “Pakistani”, but others, including Opposition leader Rahul Gandhi, came to his defence.

Gandhi said the truth is that the Modi government “fears” the youth and Gen Z because they are now asking questions.

“The Modi-Pradhan duo has turned yet another institution into a symbol of malpractice. For the first time in decades, such serious questions have been raised regarding the CBSE board examinations. 18.5 lakh students appeared for the exams -- yet for over a week, complaints regarding OSM errors, incorrect marking, and evaluation irregularities have gone unheard, while the Education minister clings to his chair,” he said in a post in Hindi on X.

The leader of Opposition in the Lok Sabha pointed out that a 17-year-old student, whose answer sheet was “incorrectly” evaluated, took to social media in the hope of finding justice.

AMID ONGOING BUZZ OVER LEADERSHIP ROW

Invited by Cong high command to Delhi for meeting: Siddaramaiah

OUR CORRESPONDENT

BENGALURU: Amid buzz over leadership change and a Cabinet reshuffle in Karnataka, Chief Minister Siddaramaiah on Monday said the Congress high command has invited him to Delhi on May 26 for a meeting.

He, however, said he was unaware of the meeting’s agenda.

“I’m invited to Delhi. Tomorrow there is a meeting by 11 am. I don’t know the subject. But, I’m invited. Last night, K C Venugopal (AICC general secretary - Organisation) called me and intimidated to me about the date and the meeting,” Siddaramaiah told reporters in response to a question on his visit to the national capital.

To a question regarding speculation surrounding his meeting with the high command, he said, “It is always



Karnataka Chief Minister Siddaramaiah addresses a press conference, in Bengaluru, Monday

daramaiah told reporters in response to a question on his visit to the national capital.

To a question regarding speculation surrounding his meeting with the high command, he said, “It is always

there.”

Speculations are rife about the leadership change and cabinet reshuffle, as the government completed three years in office on May 20.

According to party and official sources, although the Congress high command is widely expected to discuss resolving the leadership tussle between Siddaramaiah and his deputy D K Shivakumar, discussions may also involve upcoming elections to four Rajya Sabha seats from Karnataka, of which Congress can win three. The rollout of SIR of electoral rolls in the state might also figure in the meeting.

NARESH BISWANI

NEW DELHI: Union Home minister Amit Shah will undertake visits to several border regions across the country over the coming weeks to review security arrangements and interact with security personnel deployed along India’s international borders.

Observation of field conditions forms part of the intent. Interactions with ground-level forces will occur amid site inspections. Movement patterns follow strategic timing rather than fixed routes. Focus remains on operational readiness in remote sectors. Presence on location allows firsthand understanding of deployment challenges. Engagement stems from routine oversight mechanisms.

On Tuesday, Amit Shah is expected to visit BSF Post in

Takeaways

- » Observation of field conditions forms part of the intent
- » On Tuesday, Amit Shah is expected to visit BSF Post in Bikaner

Bikaner. Later, activities are set to begin involving engagement with deployed personnel. Welfare measures aimed at supporting security force members will be launched during the event.

Meanwhile, discussion on frontier safeguards begins under the Home minister’s direction in Bikaner. Participation includes personnel from the federal home department alongside regional executives from Rajasthan. Leadership figures from the Border Security Force appear too. Also

present: administrative heads and law enforcement supervisors representing five adjacent territorial zones near the boundary line.

On May 29, a stop in Bhuj, Gujarat forms part of Shah’s forthcoming border engagement schedule. Expected at BSF outposts, his presence coincides with an evaluation of safeguards along the India-Pakistan frontier, specifically around Harami Nala - a zone marked by strategic vulnerability. Though routine, such visits follow patterns seen before, yet each carries its own weight.

Security post checks unfold not solely as protocol but stem from ongoing regional assessment needs. The location, remote yet critical, draws attention due to its proximity constraints. While field inspections may seem procedural, they feed into broader oversight mechanisms. Coordination between central agencies remains visible through these movements. Presence at the site does more than signal vigilance - it enables firsthand insight.

A visit by the Home minister to Tripura falls on June 5, aimed at examining security protocols alongside border oversight across the northeast. While scrutiny of regional safeguards takes place, coordination in frontier zones will be under assessment during the trip.

Mid-June likely brings Amit Shah to West Bengal. Border regions may receive his attention around the fifteenth. Security discussions could follow during stops along the frontier edge. Infiltration matters are anticipated among meeting topics. Presence near sensitive zones might signal focus on regional safeguards.

STRAY DOGS CASE

SC refuses to entertain mentioning of plea over Punjab CM’s statement

NEW DELHI: The Supreme Court on Monday refused to entertain the mentioning of a plea which alleged that Punjab Chief Minister Bhagwant Mann had said that the apex court has given a “free hand” to kill stray dogs.

“If a chief minister makes a statement, does that mean we have to change our order?” a bench of Justices Vikram Nath and Sandeep Mehta told the counsel, who mentioned the matter.

The counsel said after the top court’s May 19 order in the stray dogs case, the Punjab chief minister had allegedly stated that the Supreme Court “has given a free hand to kill stray dogs”.

“You go to the Punjab and Haryana High Court,” the bench observed, adding, “We are not entertaining your mentioning”.

The counsel claimed that stray dogs were being killed after the top court’s order.

“Go to the Punjab and Haryana High Court,” the bench observed, adding that there has to be strict compliance of its directions passed in the stray dogs case. When the counsel said that he be allowed to withdraw the application to approach the high court, the bench said the applicant can move there.

Mann had said in a post on X in Punjabi last week that “Following the Honourable Supreme Court’s decision, the Punjab government will launch a massive campaign starting tomorrow to eliminate stray and killer dogs that pose a threat to the lives of children and passersby...Thanks to the Supreme Court”.

In a significant verdict delivered on May 19, the top court allowed euthanasia of rabid, incurably ill, dangerous and aggressive dogs to curb threat to human lives, saying the right to live with dignity encompasses the right to move freely without the threat of harm from canines.

Assam: Bhutan PM discusses regional cooperation issues with Guv and CM

GUWAHATI: Bhutan Prime Minister Dasho Tshering Tobgay met Assam governor and chief minister on Monday, and discussed with them ways to enhance cooperation with India’s northeastern region.

Tobgay, who arrived in Assam earlier in the day, called on Governor Lakshman Prasad Acharya at the Lok Bhavan. There, he held a meeting with the governor and Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma.

“The meeting saw elaborate discussions on a wide range of issues on strengthening bilateral ties and enhancing cooperation in the larger interest of the northeast region, with a particular focus on Assam,” the statement said.

A cultural evening, showcas-



Assam Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma felicitates Bhutan Prime Minister Dasho Tshering Tobgay, at Lok Bhavan in Guwahati on Monday

ing the heritage and hospitality of Assam, was also organised in honour of the visiting dignitary.

Sarma, in a post on X, said Assam was playing a pivotal role in strengthening the relations between India and Bhutan.

“Honoured to welcome and call on Hon’ble Prime Minister of Bhutan, H.E @tsheringtobgay in Guwahati. Bharat and Bhutan share a very special civilisational relationship, and under the leadership of Prime Minister Narendra Modi.

“Assam is playing a pivotal role in strengthening this relationship, which will define the growth of the South Asian region in the 21st century,” he said.

Earlier in the day, state Cabinet minister Atul Bora received the Bhutan prime minister at the state guest house here and later said that he expected the visit would open new avenues of goodwill, cooperation and cultural exchange between Assam and Bhutan.

President Murmu confers 66 Padma Awards

Late actor Dharmendra, violinist N Rajam honoured at the Rashtrapati Bhavan

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: President Droupadi Murmu on Monday conferred the Padma Vibhushan on Bollywood actor Dharmendra posthumously and classical musician and violinist N Rajam at a Civil Investiture Ceremony at the Rashtrapati Bhavan here.

As the name of Dharmendra’s wife Hema Malini, a BJP MP, was announced to receive his award for his exceptional and distinguished service in the field of art, their daughter Ahana Deol, sitting in the audience, broke down in tears.

Rajam was honoured for her pioneering contribution to Indian classical music, especially for revolutionising violin performance through the ‘Gayaki Ang’ style that replicates vocal music on the instrument.

Murmu conferred the Padma Bhushan on Bhagat Singh Koshyari, former Uttarakhand chief minister; Shata-vadhani R Ganesh, acclaimed polymath who revived the challenging classical Indian art form ‘Avadhana’; Uday Suresh Kumar Kotak, founder of Kotak Mahindra Bank; and gastroenterologist Kallipatti Ramasamy



President Droupadi Murmu confers the Padma Vibhushan to veteran actor Dharmendra posthumously, received by BJP MP Hema Malini on his behalf, during a Civil Investiture Ceremony, at Rashtrapati Bhavan in New Delhi, Monday

Palaniswamy.

She also conferred the award posthumously on ad guru Piyush Pandey and former parliamentarian Vijay Kumar Malhotra. Pandey’s wife and Malhotra’s son received the awards.

For 2026, the President has approved conferment of 131 Padma Awards -- five Padma

Vibhushan, 13 Padma Bhushan and 113 Padma Shri. At the ceremony on Monday, she conferred two Padma Vibhushan, six Padma Bhushan and 58 Padma Shri.

The remaining Padma awardees will be conferred in the second round of the ceremony to be held later, sources said.

Indian women’s cricket team captain Harmanpreet Kaur Bhullar, actor Prosenjit Chatterjee, para athlete Praveen Kumar and former Central Reserve Police Force (CRPF) director general K Vijay Kumar received the Padma Shri.

Folk musician Mir Haji Kasam, Tamil devotional music artist N Swaminathan and Raj-

Key Points

- » Murmu also conferred the award posthumously on ad guru Piyush Pandey and former parliamentarian Vijay Kumar Malhotra
- » The remaining Padma awardees will be conferred in the second round of the ceremony to be held later, sources said

asthan folk artist Taga Ram Bhil, known for playing the traditional wind instrument Algoja, were among those honoured for their contribution to art and culture.

Silambam master K Pajani-vel was awarded for promoting the ancient Tamil martial art, while hockey coach Baldev Singh was honoured for mentoring several top Indian players.

Kantha embroidery artist Tripti Mukherjee was also among the honorees.

Social worker Janardan Bapurao Bothe was honoured for rural upliftment and promotion of the Gramgeeta philosophy.

Nation Briefs

CENSUS TO BE CONDUCTED IN TWO PHASES IN HIMACHAL PRADESH

SHIMLA: The census is set to be conducted in two phases in the state. The first phase will include House Listing and Housing Census, while the second phase will involve Population Enumeration, Director Census Operations cum Citizen Registration, Himachal Pradesh, Deep Shikha Sharma said on Monday. She revealed this while appraising Chief Minister Sukhvinder Singh Sukhu about various aspects of Census-2027, a statement issued here said. The first phase will be carried out from June 16 to July 15. This time, a new facility of ‘Self Enumeration’ has also been introduced, which could be availed through the self-enumeration portal (se.census.gov.in) from June 1 to 15.

PREZ TO VISIT NATHU LA PASS DURING 3-DAY SIKKIM VISIT FROM MAY 26

NEW DELHI/GANGTOK: President Droupadi Murmu will visit Nathu La Pass on India-China border during her three-day Sikkim visit beginning Tuesday. Murmu will visit Namgyal Institute of Tibetology at Gangtok on Tuesday, the president’s office said in a statement on Monday. “On May 27, the President will visit Nathu La Pass. On the same day, she will also grace the convocation ceremony of Sikkim University at Gangtok,” it said. Murmu will present the President of India’s Police Colour to the Sikkim Police at Gangtok on May 28, the statement added. A total of 13,782 degrees will be awarded during the convocation ceremony, the Sikkim University said in a statement.

‘TRUMP A BIG MODI FAN’

Rubio downplays ‘anti-India’ rhetoric row

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: President Donald Trump is a big fan of India and Prime Minister Narendra Modi, US Secretary of State Marco Rubio said on Monday, seeking to dismiss allegations of rising anti-India rhetoric in the US.

The top diplomat's remarks on Monday came against the backdrop of a swirling controversy after the video of his response to a reporter's question on Sunday on instances of alleged racism towards Indians in the US went viral.

Though the reporter did not clarify, many saw his question as a reference to Trump's remarks referring to India, along with China, as a "hell-hole", appearing to accuse people from the two countries of abusing America's birthright citizenship.

The US Secretary of State is currently on a four-day trip to India that is aimed at recali-



US Secretary of State Marco Rubio with his wife Jeanette Rubio and US Ambassador to India Sergio Gor during their visit to Amer Fort, in Jaipur district, Monday

librating the bilateral relations that have faced headwinds since mid-last year.

"The President is a big fan of India, a big fan of Prime Minister Modi. I wouldn't be here if the President didn't want

me to be here. He wouldn't have sent someone like Sergio (Gor) to be our ambassador, someone who's very close to the President," Rubio said.

Rubio said this when a journalist this morning asked about

HIGHLIGHTS

» Rubio's remarks came against the backdrop of a swirling controversy after the video of his response to a reporter's question on instances of alleged racism towards Indians in the US went viral

» Though the reporter did not clarify, many saw his question as a reference to Trump's remarks referring to India, along with China, as a 'hellhole'

» The US Secretary of State is currently on a four-day trip to India that is aimed at recalibrating the bilateral relations that have faced headwinds since mid-last year

» 'The President is a big fan of India, a big fan of Prime Minister Modi. I wouldn't be here if the President didn't want me to be here...' Rubio said

ring to but he did not respond. "The bottom line is that in the modern era, you go online, and there are people saying all kinds of crazy stuff. I don't even know if they're real people or who they are," he said.

Rubio indicated that he thought the reporter was referring to comments by people online.

The reporter had asked: "There have been a lot of racist comments coming from the United States against Indians, Indian-Americans. You know this goes against the basic premise of the India-US relationship. What's your take on that?"

When Rubio asked whom he was referring to, the reporter responded by saying: "We all have seen those comments. We've seen endorsement of those comments."

Rubio remarked that "every country has stupid people" while responding to the question.

PREPAREDNESS, SURVEILLANCE MEASURES REVIEWED

No Ebola case reported in India so far: Health minister JP Nadda

NEW DELHI: No case of Ebola Virus Disease has been reported in the country so far, the government said on Monday as Union Health Minister J P Nadda reviewed the preparedness and surveillance measures to prevent any possible outbreak in India.

According to an official statement, during a high-level meeting with senior officials of the Union Health Ministry, Nadda assessed the country's readiness amid global concern over Ebola and directed that all preventive mechanisms remain fully alert and operational.

On the minister's directions, the Union Health Secretary

Nadda instructed authorities to keep Ebola screening arrangements at all points of entry across the country

chaired a joint review meeting with officials from various ministries and agencies concerned to strengthen coordination and preparedness measures, it said.

Nadda instructed authorities to keep Ebola screening arrangements at all points of entry across the country, including airports, seaports and land

border crossings, fully vigilant and robust, it said.

He also directed the Indian Council of Medical Research (ICMR) and the National Centre for Disease Control (NCDC) to ensure that all necessary arrangements for tracking, testing and surveillance remain in a constant state of readiness.

The Centre has intensified precautionary measures after the World Health Organization declared the Ebola outbreak a Public Health Emergency of International Concern (PHEIC). Officials said surveillance at ports of entry and coordination among agencies are being closely monitored. MPOST

UCC Bill introduced in Assam Assembly

GUWAHATI: The Assam government on Monday tabled a Bill on the Uniform Civil Code, seeking to ban polygamy and make registration of live-in relationships compulsory.

The Bill, however, said that it will not be applicable to any of the Scheduled Tribes residing in Assam. It proposed several punitive measures, including seven years imprisonment for bigamy or polygamy, and three months in jail for not registering a live-in relationship.

Parliamentary Affairs Minister Atul Bora tabled 'The Uniform Civil Code, Assam, 2026 Bill' in the first assembly session of the third BJP-led NDA government, on behalf of Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma. The Opposition parties, including Congress, Rajgor Dal and Trinamool Congress, opposed the move and demanded wider consultation with all stakeholders before its introduction.

The Assam UCC, a contentious and polarising issue that was part of BJP's election manifesto, is likely to come up for discussion on Wednesday, the last day of the ongoing five-day session. "The Bill aims to consolidate and simplify laws governing marriage, divorce, succession, and live-in relationships," Sarma said in its 'Statement of Object and Reasons'.

For marriage, the Bill sets 21 years and 18 years as minimum age for men and women, respectively, and prohibits polygamy, he said. "Importantly, it protects Assam's cultural diversity by allowing marriages to be performed according to existing religious and customary rites," Sarma said. To safeguard legal rights, the Bill proposes to make marriage and divorce registration compulsory, which will be vital for securing maintenance, inheritance and other legal protection for spouses...For the first time, the Bill provides a legal framework for live-in relationships. By requiring registration, the law ensures that the rights of partners – and any children born from such unions – are formally recognised and protected," the CM said. AGENCIES

Maharashtra: Eight killed as SUV plunges into deep gorge in Raigad

MUMBAI: Eight persons were killed after an SUV plunged nearly 1,500 feet into a deep gorge in Maharashtra's Raigad district, officials said on Monday. The accident occurred in the Ambenali Ghat area on Poladpur-Mahabaleshwar road, located about 180 km from Mumbai, between 5 am and 6 am on Sunday, when the victims were on their way from Dapoli to Satara.

The victims, in the age group of 19 to 35, left from Harne in Dapoli at around 2 am on Sunday in the SUV. When they did not reach Satara, their relatives launched a search in the afternoon and later approached the police.

During the investigation, the victims' last location was traced through a mobile tower near Poladpur. While searching in

THE MISHAP

» The accident took place in the Ambenali Ghat section on the Poladpur-Mahabaleshwar road

» The victims, travelling from Harne in Dapoli to Satara, had left around 2 am on Sunday

the Ambenali Ghat section, the police spotted the SUV in the deep gorge on Monday morning, the official said.

The police suspect that the accident occurred after the driver lost control of the vehicle in the ghat area.

Chief Minister Devendra Fadnavis expressed grief over the death of eight persons and said rescue operations were being

carried out on a war footing.

Three bodies had been recovered so far, while efforts were underway to retrieve the remaining bodies with the help of the National Disaster Response Force (NDRF) and voluntary rescue teams, he said.

One of the deceased was from Ratnagiri district, while the seven others belonged to Satara district, Fadnavis said.

The Raigad and Satara police were coordinating during the rescue operation, he added.

The victims have been identified as Ritesh Lokhande (22), Suhas Lokhande (20), Utkarsh Shingte (21), Nikhil Shingte (25), Mahesh Pawar (25), Aditya Salunkhe (21), Rajesh Katkar (35), all the residents of Satara, and Ansh Chavan (19), belonging to Ratnagiri, according to police. MPOST

SC BATS FOR EDUCATIONAL EQUITY

‘Girls must not quit school due to lack of sanitary pads, toilets’

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: The Supreme Court on Monday stressed that girls should not give up education only for the reason that sanitary napkins and functional, gender-segregated toilets are not available at schools and asked the Centre to ensure that its directions in this regard are effectively complied with in letter and spirit.

The apex court's observation came after the Centre said its January 30 judgement directing authorities to provide free sanitary napkins to girl students and functional, gender-segregated toilets at schools has led to galvanisation of efforts in all states and Union Territories.

"Make good use of it. It is for the good of women and girls of this country. Girls should not give up education and sit at home and do some domestic work only for this reason," a bench of Justices J B Pardiwala and R Mahadevan observed.

"Now, it is for you to make the most of it and see that as far as possible, the benefits are extended in terms of our

KEY POINTS

» The SC asked the Centre to ensure that its directions in this regard are effectively complied with in letter and spirit

» In the landmark judgment delivered on January 30, the apex court directed all states and UTs to provide free oxo-biodegradable sanitary



napkins to girl students and functional, gender-segregated toilets for all students at schools

judgment," the bench told Additional Solicitor General Archana Pathak Dave, who was appearing for the Centre.

In the landmark judgment delivered on January 30 to ensure gender justice and educational equity, the apex court directed all states and UTs to provide free oxo-biodegradable sanitary napkins to girl students and functional, gender-segregated toilets for all students at schools. It had issued a slew of directions to all states and UTs to ensure that these facilities were provided in schools irrespective of whether they were

government-run, aided or private. On Monday, the law officer referred to the summary of compliance with the directions issued by the top court in its verdict.

"Are you collecting data from all the states?" the bench asked. Dave said the Centre has collected data of roughly two to two-and-a-half months from the states.

The bench said the Centre should proceed further to see that directions issued by the apex court were effectively complied with in letter and spirit.

TWISHA SHARMA DEATH

For parents, divorced daughter better than a dead one: Govt in SC

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: The Supreme Court on Monday assured a fair, independent and impartial CBI investigation into the death of former model-turned-actor Twisha Sharma, while expressing concern over the growing narrative that the judiciary was shielding the accused in the case.

Hearing the matter suo motu, a bench comprising Chief Justice of India Surya Kant and Justice Joyymalya Bagchi said it was "pained" by the public perception surrounding the investigation and urged restraint from both the media and the families involved.

"We request the media not to record statements of the victim's family and reduce their pain to sound bites," the bench observed, adding that speculation and competing narratives should be avoided while the investigation is underway.

The court was informed by Solicitor General Tushar Mehta, appearing for the Madhya Pradesh government, that the Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI) is likely to formally take over the probe within a day. He said the state government had already written to the Centre recommending a CBI inquiry into the matter.

During the hearing, Mehta made a strong observation on the social implications of the case, saying: "One thing is clear, that the girl has lost her life. Whether it is suicide or anything else, for parents the moral is that it is better to have a divorced daughter than a dead one"

Twisha Sharma, 33, was found hanging at her matrimonial home in Bhopal's Katara Hills area on May 12. Her family has accused her husband, lawyer Samarth Singh, and

The SC assured a fair probe, while expressing concern over the growing narrative that the judiciary was shielding the accused in the case

mother-in-law, former district judge Giribala Singh, of dowry harassment and abetment to suicide. The in-laws, however, have claimed that Sharma was battling drug addiction.

Police have registered an FIR against Samarth Singh and Giribala Singh on charges related to dowry harassment. The case has drawn nationwide attention following allegations of institutional bias because one of the accused is a former judge. The apex court took suo motu cognisance of the matter after media reports raised concerns over procedural irregularities and possible influence in the investigation. The case has been registered under the title, "In Re: Alleged Institutional Bias and Procedural Discrepancies in the Unnatural Death of Young Woman at Matrimonial Home".

Mehta informed the court that the second autopsy of Sharma's body was conducted on Sunday by a team from AIIMS-Bhopal on the directions of the Madhya Pradesh High Court.

Senior advocate Siddharth Dave, appearing for the accused, objected to excessive media coverage and submitted that even the Section 164 CrPC statement recorded before a magistrate had been published in newspapers.

The bench urged both sides to avoid making statements in public and instead cooperate with investigators.

Saini lauds role of women journalists

CHANDIGARH: Haryana Chief Minister Nayab Singh Saini on Monday said women journalists are playing a vital role in shaping the democratic narrative of the country through their courage, commitment and professionalism.

Interacting with members of the Women Journalists Welfare Trust in New Delhi, Saini said women journalists have consistently demonstrated resilience, balance and truthfulness even while working in challenging conditions. Media Advisor to the Chief Minister, Rajeev Jaitly was also present on the occasion.

He also highlighted women-centric initiatives of the government, including the 'Beti Bachao, Beti Padhao' campaign, and said the programme has brought significant social change in the state with improvements in the sex ratio in several regions. MPOST

ter said that extensive measures have been undertaken to make the entire PMT process transparent, well-organised and candidate-friendly.

On the occasion, the chief minister also met family members accompanying the candidates and inquired about the facilities being provided to

them. Around 3,000 candidates are undergoing the PMT daily at Tau Devi Lal Stadium. For the convenience of candidates and their attendants, a dedicated rest area with adequate seating arrangements has been set up at the stadium entrance. In addition, a baggage deposit facility has also been provided.

Nation Briefs

DG UNVEILS BOOK BY CISF OFFICER



NEW DELHI: An inspirational book, 'Hogi Jai... Hey Purushottam Naveen!', authored by CISF Assistant Inspector General (Administration) Jai Prakash Azad, was released at the CISF Headquarters in New Delhi on Monday. The book was unveiled by CISF Director General Praveer Ranjan. Inspired by Mahakavi Suryakant Tripathi 'Nirala's poem Ram Ki Shakti Puja, the book highlights themes of positivity, patience and inner strength.

HARYANA REVISES BAKRID HOLIDAY TO MAY 28

CHANDIGARH: The Haryana government has revised the date of the gazetted holiday for Id-ul-Zuha (Bakrid), shifting it from May 27 to May 28. According to a notification issued by Haryana Chief Secretary Anurag Rastogi, Thursday, May 28, will now be observed as a gazetted holiday across all government departments, boards, corporations, educational institutions and other establishments under the state government.



EDITORIAL
PRICE
DOMINOES

For millions of Indians already struggling to manage household budgets, the relentless rise in fuel prices is no longer merely an economic statistic flashing across television screens. It is becoming a slow-burning national crisis that threatens to make every aspect of daily life more expensive. From vegetables transported by trucks to school bus fees, from flight tickets to electricity bills, from medicines to online deliveries, the impact of rising petrol and diesel prices inevitably seeps into every corner of the economy. The latest increase has once again exposed the structural vulnerability of the Indian economy to global crude oil shocks. Petrol and diesel prices have now climbed by nearly Rs 7.5 per litre since mid-May, while LPG and CNG prices have also moved upward. Though the immediate trigger lies in the geopolitical turmoil surrounding Iran and the Strait of Hormuz, the deeper concern is India's overwhelming dependence on imported crude oil. India imports nearly 85 per cent of its crude requirements.

The Strait of Hormuz, through which a substantial portion of the world's oil supply passes, remains among the most strategically sensitive maritime chokepoints in the world. Even the fear of disruption is enough to send global crude prices soaring. India, unfortunately, has little insulation against such volatility. The government may temporarily cushion consumers by delaying price revisions, as appears to have happened in recent weeks, but eventually the burden returns to the public through phased increases. Oil marketing companies cannot absorb losses indefinitely, particularly when under-recoveries reportedly run into hundreds of crores every day. The Indian economy is already facing persistent inflationary pressures, uneven consumption recovery and growing anxieties around employment and household savings. Fuel price inflation acts like a multiplier. It not only raises direct transportation costs but also inflates input costs across sectors. Farmers pay more for diesel used in irrigation pumps and tractors. Manufacturers spend more on freight movement. Retailers pass those costs onto consumers. Even services that appear unrelated to fuel — such as healthcare, food delivery, education and tourism — eventually become more expensive because transportation underpins modern economic activity.

The middle class and lower-income households inevitably bear the harshest impact. Wealthier sections may grumble at higher fuel bills, but poorer families are forced to alter consumption patterns altogether. Rising LPG prices can push households back towards cheaper and more polluting cooking fuels. Increased transport fares affect workers who rely on buses, autos and shared mobility. Higher food prices disproportionately hurt those already spending a major share of their income on essentials. Inflation is not merely an economic phenomenon; it is a social stress amplifier. The political dimensions of fuel pricing are equally difficult to ignore. Opposition parties have accused the government of delaying hikes until after elections, a charge that reflects the intensely political nature of fuel prices in India. Successive governments, irrespective of political affiliation, have treated fuel pricing not merely as an economic issue but as an electoral one. Excise duties on fuel have often become convenient instruments for revenue mobilisation, especially during periods of fiscal pressure. While governments defend such taxation as necessary for infrastructure spending and welfare commitments, consumers increasingly view fuel taxes as punitive.

Indeed, India's fuel taxation structure deserves closer scrutiny. Even when global crude prices softened in previous years, retail prices did not decline proportionately because taxes remained elevated. Governments at both the Centre and states derive enormous revenue from fuel taxes, making meaningful reductions fiscally difficult. Yet this dependency also exposes a troubling contradiction: public finances increasingly benefit from citizens paying more for essential energy consumption. The broader macroeconomic implications are equally serious. Rising oil prices widen India's import bill, pressure the rupee, strain foreign exchange reserves and threaten the current account balance. A weaker rupee further increases the cost of imports, creating a vicious cycle. Inflationary pressures may also constrain the Reserve Bank of India's monetary policy flexibility, reducing room for interest rate cuts that could otherwise stimulate growth. If fuel inflation persists, economic growth itself could slow as consumer spending weakens under rising costs.

The crisis should serve as a reminder of the urgent need for long-term energy reforms. India's push towards renewable energy, electric mobility and ethanol blending is strategically important not merely from an environmental perspective but from an economic sovereignty standpoint. Reducing dependence on imported fossil fuels is no longer just a climate goal; it is a national economic necessity. However, transitions of this scale require time, infrastructure and affordability. Until then, India remains tied to the volatile realities of global oil markets. Ordinary Indians are left confronting a familiar but painful reality: when fuel prices rise, nothing remains untouched. The cost of living climbs quietly but relentlessly. A litre of petrol is never merely a litre of petrol in India's economic ecosystem. It is the hidden price embedded in food, medicine, education, travel and survival itself. And unless policymakers find a more sustainable balance between fiscal compulsions, energy security and consumer protection, the burden of inflation will continue to travel from fuel stations directly into the daily lives of millions.

TALKING SHOP



RAJEEV NARAYAN

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A healthcare system that charges Rs 120 for a syringe that costs only Rs 3, Rs 2 lakh for a Rs 25,000 pacemaker, and Rs 26 lakh for a Rs 4 lakh heart valve is not just broken. It is morally hollow and pitiless at its very core

"Of all the forms of inequality, injustice in healthcare is the most shocking and inhumane."
— Martin Luther King Jr.

There are moments in life when human beings are most vulnerable. A parent gasping for breath in an emergency ward. A child burning with fever at 2 am. A spouse wheeled into a hospital's intensive care unit after a cardiac arrest. In such moments, people do not negotiate. They do not compare prices. They do not bargain over bills. They surrender to the healthcare system before them — emotionally, medically and financially. And in India, that surrender is being exploited.

The figures are staggering and tall enough to sound fictional. A syringe purchased by the healthcare provider for Rs 3 is billed at Rs 120. A pacemaker procured for Rs 25,000 is sold to patients for Rs 2 lakh. A heart valve is marked up from Rs 4 lakh to Rs 26 lakh. In a recent analysis, the National Pharmaceutical Pricing Authority revealed a shocking reality — that hospital margins on syringes often exceeded 1,200 per cent above distributor prices, while trade margins on syringes crossed 500 per cent and mark-up on needles was 250 per cent.

These are not luxury products. Nor are these premium consumer goods. These are medical necessities used on ailing, frightened patients lying on hospital beds, incapable of questioning what is being injected or billed in their name. What makes the situation all the more disturbing is that this profiteering does not thrive in secrecy, but in plain sight. India has world-class hospitals, cutting-edge diagnostic chains and globally-celebrated medical expertise. But beneath the gleaming healthcare architecture lies a marketplace where illness has been turned into a commercial opportunity. The tragedy is not only economic, it is ethical as well.

Business of Illness

The private healthcare sector argues that quality care requires



The debate is no longer on whether India needs healthcare reform. It is about whether India can afford to delay it

investment, infrastructure, imported equipment, trained specialists and advanced technology. And all of it costs money. They are right. But there is a profound difference between charging like a saviour with its own needs and charging like the Grim Reaper. Scrutiny into medical bills revealed how many hospitals were procuring consumables at low prices, while billing patients at highly-inflated MRPs. The All India Drug Action Network has protested that "hospitals are fleecing patients", pointing out that artificially-inflated MRPs bear no relationship to actual costs.

Why does this distortion persist? Well, it does because the system allows it to, and perhaps even encourages it.

In much of India, there are no enforceable caps on hospital consumables, diagnostics, procedures or emergency care costs. Regulation remains fragmented and inconsistent. In effect, vast sections of the healthcare economy operate with vagabond pricing freedom in a sector where consumers possess next to no bargaining power. A patient entering a hospital is not a customer entering a shopping mall. There is no 'market choice' available during a medical emergency. Fear vanquishes rational consumption and calculations. Any and all prescriptions are accepted without challenge. Bills are paid because a life hangs in the balance barely some meters away.

This imbalance of power cre-

ates fertile ground for abuse. And the abuse is becoming institutionalised.

Studies have found that many private hospitals earn profits ranging from 350-1,700 per cent on consumables and medical supplies. Diagnostics, too, has emerged as a major contributor to inflated billing. Patients often complain that initial cost estimates balloon three-fold or four-fold before discharge. Even the language used by healthcare regulators is cause for alarm. NPPA once described the pricing of consumables as 'unethical profiteering in a failed market system'. It is difficult to argue this soul-less branding.

Insurance Illusion

For lakhs and crores of Indians, health insurance was designed to provide protection from exactly this kind of financial catastrophe. Yet, the reality tells is totally different. Despite rising insurance coverage, most Indians continue paying large medical bills out of their own pockets. According to the latest National Statistical Office survey, out-of-pocket expenditure dominates hospitalisation costs in India. Rural patients cough up nearly 95 per cent of hospitalisation expenses themselves, while urban patients pay around 83 per cent.

The numbers are more troubling when viewed alongside healthcare inflation. Healthcare costs have doubled in recent years, driven primarily by private healthcare providers. This

denudes a glaring contradiction of modern healthcare: insurance penetration may be rising, but financial protection remains weak. Most policies exclude critical treatments during waiting periods. Some cap room rents or restrict reimbursements using hidden clauses incomprehensible to consumers. Hospitals push expensive procedures, diagnostics or consumables, even when they fall beyond insurer-approved limits, leaving families struggling to absorb the difference.

In practice, insurance reduces suffering only marginally, and rarely ever eliminates it. The result is a near death-blow for the middle-class and catastrophic for the poor. Savings evaporate. Jewellery is mortgaged. Loans are taken. Land is sold. Families slide into debt because a loved one fell ill. Healthcare-induced poverty is one of India's least discussed national crises.

The Silent Divide

The undeniable fact is that today's India operates with two parallel healthcare realities. One India waits for hours in overcrowded government hospitals, hoping affordability compensates for overburdened infrastructure. The other India walks into polished private facilities offering speed, comfort and sophisticated treatment — at prices most cannot even dream of paying. And neither system fully satisfies the promise of equitable healthcare.

To be fair, government hospitals have improved. Studies indicate a growing use of public health services and lower out-of-pocket expenses in public institutions. But public healthcare continues to struggle with uneven quality, manpower shortages and severe pressure in densely-populated cities. The resultant vacuum allows private healthcare to dominate critical and specialised care. Unlike sectors such as aviation, telecom or banking, healthcare cannot function purely through market logic. For the consequences of failure are not delayed deliveries or poor customer experiences. They are death, bankruptcies and shattered lives.

The moral hazard becomes all the more dangerous when hospitals turn into revenue-maximising corporations answerable only on financial targets and not on patient welfare. Worldwide, concerns about over-prescription, unnecessary procedures and inflated medical billing have emerged when healthcare is allowed to become overtly commercialised. India is no exception. The difference is that India's regulatory safeguards are weaker.

Restoring Humanity

The debate is no longer on whether India needs healthcare reform. It is about whether India can afford to delay it. The country requires a national framework governing hospital pricing, consumables, emergency care billing and diagnostic charges. Itemised billing should be made mandatory and simple to understand. Trade margins on critical medical devices and consumables should face strict scrutiny. Insurance contracts need simplification and grievance redressal mechanisms must become faster and patient-centric. Most important, healthcare must stop being treated as an industry and be restored to its status as 'a public good', 'a public need'.

Nations worldwide are wrestling with healthcare affordability. Look at America's insurance battles and Europe's fiscal burdens. But India's challenge is different. And it is uniquely severe because it combines inequality with weak regulation, rising privatisation and runaway population.

A civilisation is ultimately judged not by the height of its skyscrapers or the size of its economy, but by how it treats people when they are at their weakest. Hospitals are places where fear should encounter compassion, not one where discharge bills are designed to ambush. When a healthcare system charges a desperate patient Rs 120 for a syringe worth Rs 3, it is not overpricing a product. It is placing a price tag on human helplessness.

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India's New Era of Deterrence

A year after India's bold cross-border operation, Operation Sindoor remains a symbol of military precision, political will, and a transformed national security framework

SECURITY DOCTRINE



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The message is loud and clear for the global community, particularly for Pakistan and its allies, who have often underestimated India's military capability and efficacy

May 7 this year marked the first anniversary of Operation Sindoor, which brought immense pride and honour to the country by striking Pakistani military and terrorist targets, while also demonstrating India's military might, particularly that of the Air Force, backed by sophisticated science and technology.

It may be reiterated that India created history by successfully conducting Operation Sindoor in the wee hours of May 7, 2025, precisely targeting nine high-value targets well inside Pakistan, including Markaz Subhan Allah, Bahawalpur; Markaz Taiba, Muridke; Sarjal, Tehra Kalan; Mehmoona Joya, Sialkot; Markaz Ahle Hadith, Barnala; Markaz Abbas and Maskar Raheel Shahid, both in Kotli; and Shawai Nalla Camp and Syedna Bilal Camp, both in Muzaffarabad. These locations were hit with surgical accuracy, annihilating them completely. This was no mean achievement. The operation reflected extraordinary professionalism, as all the pinpointed targets were citadels of terror outfits, including Lashkar-e-Taiba (LeT), Jaish-e-Mohammad (JeM), and their affiliates. Professionally, Operation Sindoor was not only the most effective cross-border strike carried out by India since the Balakot operation of 2019, but it also displayed India's strategic capabilities. It may also be reiterated that the operation came in the wake of the April 22 terror attack in Pahalgam, where 26 innocents were slain mercilessly.

It is also significant to recall that, unlike the 2016 Uri and 2019 Balakot airstrikes, or other previous Indian operations of a similar nature that were limited in scale and scope, Operation Sindoor was technologically precise, extensive, and unprecedented. The decision to strike deep into Pakistan-occupied territory revealed one thing clearly: a departure from earlier thinking. This time, the approach



Operation Sindoor signalled that India's response to terrorism would no longer remain confined by old strategic limitations

was offensive, result-oriented, and without any margin of error. The sheer extent of damage inflicted on the Pakistan-based terror camps sent a strong message to terrorist syndicates and their handlers. In the aftermath of Operation Sindoor, India reserves the right to strike pre-emptively, suggesting that no location is beyond its reach. The message is loud and clear for the global community, particularly for Pakistan and its allies, who have often underestimated India's military capability and efficacy, or at least pretended to do so.

The Pahalgam terror attack was perpetrated by The Resistance Front (TRF), another name for LeT. Operation Sindoor was conceived in response to this attack. It was not merely a retaliatory show of force, but an attempt to degrade the logistical and operational foundations of terrorism emanating from Pakistani soil. Even now, Pakistan continues to remain shaken after "Sindoor." Yet, it is bizarre to observe Pakistan's reaction on the first anniversary of the operation. Lieutenant General Ahmed Sharif Chaudhry, Director General of Inter-Services Public Relations (DG ISPR), on May 7 this year claimed that Pakistan had inflicted a "crushing defeat" on a five-times-larger enemy across all fronts in Marka-e-Haq. The term Marka-e-Haq refers to the

2025 conflict with India, which began with the April 22 Pahalgam attack and concluded with a ceasefire on May 10 last year following Operation Bunyanum Marsoos. Addressing a press conference in the presence of senior Pakistani military officials marking one year since the completion of Marka-e-Haq, he even congratulated the nation, claiming that Pakistan had defeated India on every front during the conflict and describing it as a humiliating defeat for the adversary. Such exaggerated and manufactured claims once again expose Pakistan's immature and baseless narrative. It is also important to state here that Pakistan suffered defeat during "Operation Gibraltar", launched through the abortive tribal infiltration into Kashmir in 1947-48. Again, it decisively lost the wars of 1965 and 1971, where the defeats were not only outright and absolute, but Pakistan also lost its eastern flank, which is now Bangladesh as an independent country. Similarly, Pakistan tasted humiliating defeat in its failed military misadventure during the Kargil conflict of 1999.

Now, what were the immediate implications of Operation Sindoor, both preceding the strike and in its aftermath? The successful operation confirmed that there was perfect coordination between the political and military

leadership, a free hand given by the Prime Minister to the armed forces to deal with the challenges, complete secrecy, and seamless synergy among the government, intelligence agencies, security establishments, and other connected organisations. In sum, it must be told and retold that there was a flawless political will to send a clear message to Pakistan that, should it dare repeat such a misadventure, it would face disastrous consequences.

The operation also enhanced India's image within the international community, and it is no exaggeration to say that India today stands comparable to countries like Israel in conducting such bold operations. Operation Sindoor also remains a class apart because it struck only terror camps, exercised caution to spare civilian lives, and targeted only those responsible for the Pahalgam terror attack. Last but not least, the nation stood united, cutting across party, caste, and religious lines. Such facts deserve repetition even after one year, so that public memory remains refreshed.

Further, on the first anniversary of Operation Sindoor, senior military officials asserted that India's response to cross-border terrorism had changed the security scenario, and that this was not an end, but merely the beginning. In the same vein, Defence Minister Rajnath Singh described the operation as a "unique" example of how the Indian military utilised advanced technology to deliver a decisive blow to terror groups and their "patrons". Addressing an event in Prayagraj, Uttar Pradesh, Mr. Singh emphasised that while the armed forces "showed patience", they were clinical in destroying terrorist infrastructure. He added that the operation served as a global reminder of the Indian military's capabilities. He further stated that advanced missile systems, including Akash and BrahMos, along

with a host of the latest equipment, were used during the operation. Referring to the prevailing geopolitical environment, the Defence Minister underlined the need for the military to remain alert and adapt continuously to changing circumstances.

There have also been several reactions within India from strategic experts and political leaders. Likewise, Lieutenant General (Retired) Syed Ata Hasnain, former Military Commander, noted strategist, and now Governor of Bihar, observed that "the most striking feature of Sindoor was not the scale of force employed, but the discipline with which it was applied. India chose not to be drawn into a wider conventional conflict, despite having both the capability and the provocation to do so. Instead, it demonstrated a doctrine of aggression blended with restraint — precise, time-bound, and politically directed." He further remarked that "the legacy of Operation Sindoor, therefore, lies not just in what it achieved, but in what it revealed. It showed that India can act with precision without losing control, that it can send a decisive message without inviting uncontrolled escalation, and that it can align its instruments of national power in pursuit of clear strategic objectives."

Analytically speaking, Pakistan should not remain under any illusion that it had gained the upper hand over India during Operation Sindoor. It should also discard its misconceptions that having "brokered" the Iran-US "peace" deal, or receiving "praise" from President Donald Trump, has elevated Pakistan's standing within the international community. It must be stated forthrightly that Pakistan continues to remain a state harbouring terrorists, promoting cross-border terrorism, and vitiating world peace through acts and gestures of acrimony.

Views expressed are personal

US PREZ ASKS MEDIATORS TO JOIN ABRAHAM ACCORDS

Trump: Iran talks progressing ‘nicely’

WASHINGTON: US President Donald Trump on Monday said negotiations with Iran to end the war were progressing “nicely”, but officials pointed out that a final decision may take some time due to the complex communication networks Tehran deploys to consult with its supreme leader.

In a post on Truth Social, Trump also said that countries involved in the peace talks with Iran should sign on to the Abraham Accords, which deal with establishing diplomatic, economic and security ties between Israel and Arab nations. He said it would be an honour to have Iran as a signatory to the Accords.

“...after all the work done by the United States to try and pull this very complex puzzle together, it should be mandatory that all of these Countries, at a minimum, simultaneously, sign onto the Abraham Accords,” Trump said, adding that it may be accepted if one or two have a reason for not doing so. Among the negotiators, the



US President Donald Trump

AP/PTI

UAE and Bahrain are already members of the Accords, and Trump expects Saudi Arabia, Qatar, Pakistan, Turkiye, Egypt and Jordan to sign up.

According to US officials, Iranian Supreme Leader Mojtaba Khamenei is operating from an undisclosed location with little access to the outside world and is only reached by a labyrinth of couriers.

When the US sends proposed details, it takes time for

officials in Tehran to reach the supreme leader, delaying a possible response.

A senior administration official on Sunday said the supreme leader had agreed to the contours of the current draft agreement, and Trump posted on Truth Social that he anticipated final word in the next few days.

US media reports said most Iranian leaders don't see daylight, spending weeks

Highlights

- » US President says it would be an honour to have Iran as a signatory to the Accords
- » Among the negotiators, the UAE and Bahrain are already members of the Accords
- » When the US sends proposed details, it takes time for officials in Tehran to reach the supreme leader

inside highly fortified bunkers and avoiding speaking to each other unless necessary. By design, even officials at the highest levels of the Iranian government don't know where Khamenei is and have no way to contact him directly. Instead, messages are passed through a network of couriers created to obscure the supreme leader's location.

Israel and the US launched the war on February 28, vowing

to destroy Iran's ballistic missile program, end its support for proxy militant groups across the region and end Iran's ability to pursue a nuclear bomb. Both Netanyahu and President Donald Trump also said they hoped to create conditions to topple Iran's government.

According to regional officials, under the current deal being discussed, Iran would give up its stockpile of highly enriched uranium and reopen the strategic Strait of Hormuz in exchange for ending a US blockade of Iranian ports and the lifting of sanctions against Iran. Key details on Iran's nuclear program would then be negotiated during 60 days. It is unclear if the deal will address Iran's missiles or support for regional militant groups. Israel's opposition leader Yair Lapid on Monday expressed gratitude to Trump for launching the war with Israel, but criticised Netanyahu for allowing Washington to negotiate a potential deal with little coordination with Israel.

Missile and drone strikes kill eight in Russia and Ukraine

KYIV: At least eight people have been killed in missile and drone attacks on Russian and Ukrainian territory in the past 24 hours, local authorities on both sides said on Monday, with damage reported to energy infrastructure in Russia's Belgorod region.

The strikes follow one of the heaviest Russian bombardments of Kyiv since the start of the four-year war, after Moscow vowed on Saturday to retaliate for what it described as a deliberate drone strike on a student dorm in the Russian-controlled Luhansk region. Ukraine's military denied the Russian accusations and said it had struck an elite drone command unit in the area.

Since then, four people, including two teenagers, have been killed in the Russian-controlled eastern Ukrainian town of Horlivka, its mayor Ivan Prikhodko said on Monday on Telegram, blaming Ukrainian armed aggression.



Rescue workers try to put out a fire at a residential building after a Russian strike on Kyiv

AP/PTI

“THE STRIKES FOLLOW ONE OF THE HEAVIEST RUSSIAN BOMBARDMENTS OF KYIV SINCE THE START OF THE FOUR-YEAR WAR”

In Russia's Belgorod region, one man was killed and

another injured in a missile and drone attack that also cut power and water supplies, local authorities said on Telegram.

In Ukraine, two people were killed and 16 wounded in Russian shelling, missile and drone attacks in the southern Kherson region over the past 24 hours, regional governor Oleksandr Prokudin said on Telegram on Monday.

CALIFORNIA

Risk of a catastrophic explosion eliminated at chemical tank: Officials

NEW YORK: The risk of a catastrophic explosion at a damaged chemical tank in Southern California has been eliminated following a close overnight inspection that confirmed a crack in the tank relieved pressure and cooled the chemical, authorities said Monday.

Officials said crews conducted tank temperature checks at night to reduce risks to firefighters, avoiding daytime operations when heat from the tank made conditions around it most dangerous.

The overnight mission allowed crews to verify the crack and confirm temperatures were falling, Orange County Fire Authority division chief Craig Covey said Monday morning. Covey said the results of overnight evaluation of the tank — that the temperature inside had dropped and that pressure had been released — was “incredibly positive news.”

The overnight mission allowed crews to verify the crack and confirm temperatures were falling

However, evacuation orders remained in place for about 50,000 people in Garden Grove, California, located south of Los Angeles.

Covey said falling temperatures and the release of pressure from the tank were allowing officials to “turn the corner on this incident” after days of concern about a possible explosion.

There has been no chemical leak as of early Monday, but the Orange County Fire Authority said the risk to public safety is “ongoing.”

Xi hails ‘unbreakable’ friendship with Pak

As he meets PM Shehbaz, Munir



Chinese President Xi Jinping, centre left, and Pakistan's Prime Minister Shehbaz Sharif, centre right, attend at the Great Hall of the People, in Beijing on Monday

AP/PTI

BEIJING/ISLAMABAD: President Xi Jinping on Monday hailed China's “unbreakable” friendship with Pakistan and commended Islamabad for taking the initiative to play a mediating role in restoring peace in West Asia as he met Prime Minister Shehbaz Sharif and Army Chief Field Marshal Asim Munir.

During the meeting at the Great Hall of the People, Xi called Shehbaz an “old friend” and said the two countries have enjoyed “mutual understanding, trust and support, and forged an unbreakable traditional friendship. Their strategic mutual trust and practical cooperation have strongly promoted the development of both nations.”

Xi also said that China firmly supports Pakistan in safeguarding its independence, sovereignty, and territorial integrity. “No matter

how the international landscape may evolve, China will always place priority on the development of China-Pakistan relations in its diplomacy with neighbouring countries,” he said.

China is ready to maintain high-level exchanges with Pakistan, strengthen strategic communication, and steer the bilateral relationship forward in the right direction, an official statement here quoted him as saying.

The two sides should accelerate the development of an even closer China-Pakistan community with a shared future in the new era and deliver more outcomes from their all-weather cooperation to better benefit the two peoples, contribute to regional peace and stability, and set a fine example for building a community with a shared future with neighbouring countries.

Pope calls for robust regulation of AI in manifesto that ponders future of humanity

VATICAN CITY: Pope Leo XIV called Monday for robust regulation of artificial intelligence and for its developers to work for the common good rather than profit, issuing a sweeping manifesto on safeguarding humankind as the technology impacts everything from work to war.

“Magnifica Humanitas” (Magnificent Humanity), Leo's first encyclical, has been eagerly awaited ever since history's first US-born pope announced days after his election that he considered AI to be the biggest challenge facing humanity today.



Pope Leo XIV arrives in Calipari Square in Acerra

AP/PTI

Experts in the tech industry, academia and Catholic morality said the document will likely become a benchmark in the debate over AI, a point of reference for policymakers, researchers and ordinary folk alike. It comes as the near-daily developments in technology trigger concerns that rise over AI replacing human jobs and even human intelligence.

“It lends itself to people who are at the forefront of

these tools and able to see the incredible things that they're able to do, to have questions about their own: What does it mean to be human?” said Taylor Black, a Microsoft AI executive and director of Catholic University of America's AI institute.

The pope was to present the text at a Vatican launch Monday that featured the co-founder of Anthropic, which is currently locked in a legal battle

Key Points

- » The pope was to present the text at a Vatican launch Monday that featured the co-founder of Anthropic
- » The Vatican decided to involve Anthropic as part of its decade-long effort to engage Silicon Valley in dialogue over the human cost of AI

Indians among tourists from 40 nations eligible for free on-arrival visas in SL

COLOMBO: Indian tourists are among visitors from 40 countries who will be granted free on-arrival visas valid for 30 days, the Sri Lankan government announced on Monday.

The Department of Immigration and Emigration said all visitors, including nationals from the 40 countries as well as those from countries having bilateral reciprocal agreements with Sri Lanka, such as

“INDIA REMAINS SRI LANKA'S LARGEST SOURCE MARKET FOR INBOUND TOURISM ARRIVALS”

Singapore, Maldives and Seychelles, are required to obtain an Electronic Travel Authorisation (ETA) before arrival.

Under the arrangement, tourists will receive a free 30-day visa with a double-entry facility permitted from the date of first arrival, it said.

India remains Sri Lanka's largest source market for inbound tourism arrivals.

Besides India, the other countries include Russia, the UK, the US, Germany, China and Denmark.

No foreign visit planned for PM Balen during 1st 100 days: Nepal govt

KATHMANDU: Nepal Prime Minister Balendra Shah, popularly known as ‘Balen’, has no plan to undertake any foreign visit during the first 100 days in office, government spokesperson Sasmit Pokharel said on Monday. Pokharel, who is also the Minister for Education, Science and Technology, said the prime minister was fully focused on implementing the government's 100-day agenda.



“The prime minister is not going to any country, not only India, at the moment,” Pokharel told reporters after the Cabinet meeting at Singha Durbar here.

“The prime minister is very much occupied with the 100-

day works plan. We are all now very much focused on the work during the 100 days,” he said.

Balen assumed office on March 27 after the RSP secured an almost two-thirds majority in the House of Representatives elections held on March 5. Pokharel also clarified that there is no link between the proposed India visit of ruling RSP chairman Rabi Lamichhane and PM Balen.

UK hits hottest-ever day in May as 32.8 C record broken

LONDON: The record for the all-time hottest day in the month of May in the UK was beaten on Monday as temperatures crossed 33.5 degrees Celsius, overtaking 32.8 degrees Celsius last recorded in May 1944.

The Meteorological (Met) Office expects temperatures to continue to rise over the next couple of hours, making the annual May Bank Holiday Monday for Spring season as the UK's most sweltering long weekend in years.

The UK Health Security Agency (UKHSA) has issued an amber heat-health alert, warning of an increase in risk for individuals aged over 65 years or those with pre-existing health conditions such as respiratory and cardiovascular diseases.

“Temperatures at Heathrow have recently reached 33.5°C, provisionally beating the all-time May record,” the UK Met Office said.

“It's not good news for hay fever sufferers. We've started the grass and wildflower pollen season and levels will reach very high counts in some southern areas on Tuesday,” it said.

The highest temperature of the ongoing heatwave was recorded at Heathrow, south-west London, with all parts of the country severely impacted by the rising mercury levels.

Muslims begin annual Hajj in sweltering heat against backdrop of war concerns

Many pilgrims have been using umbrellas for shade and carrying handheld fans

MECCA: The annual Hajj pilgrimage, one of the Five Pillars of Islam, officially began Monday.

More than 1.5 million pilgrims have arrived in Saudi Arabia from outside the country, Saleh bin Saad Al-Murabba, commander of the Hajj passport forces, said Friday.

The faithful have been pouring into the country for the Hajj against the backdrop of a tenuous ceasefire in the Iran war and related regional tensions and uncertainty.

Egyptian pilgrim Samya Abdul Moneim said she was grateful to God that she made it to the Hajj, which is required once in a lifetime of every Muslim who can afford it and is physically able to make it.

“I am in a state of blessing and happiness,” she said in Mecca on Sunday. “It's an indescribable feeling, truly. I mean, thank God, I am in a blessing.”

Typically on the first day, many pilgrims in Mecca con-



Muslim pilgrims circumambulate the Kaaba, Islam's holiest site, at the Grand Mosque, during the annual Hajj pilgrimage in Mecca on last Sunday

AP/PTI

verge on a vast tent camp in the nearby desert. Ahead of that, pilgrims have been circling the cube-shaped Kaaba in the Grand Mosque in sweltering temperatures. For pil-

grims, Hajj can be a deeply moving spiritual experience and a chance to seek God's forgiveness and the erasure of past sins. Pilgrims perform the Hajj rituals over several days.

This Hajj “is, in effect, a hard reset for me,” Youssef Chouhoud, a political scientist at Christopher Newport University in Virginia, said Monday from the tent city of

Mina. “I pray that I emerge on the other side of this journey with a new sense of purpose and the discipline to see it through.”

Around him, many pilgrims were resting and refuelling, he said via WhatsApp, noting how demanding the pilgrimage is.

“It is for many pilgrims the most difficult thing they will ever do in their lives,” he said. “But nothing this meaningful is ever going to be easy.”

He found it inspiring “to see so many who have sacrificed so much to be here ... only to compete with one another in giving charity and helping each other along the way,” he said. “All this in the hope that their intentions and actions may be accepted by their Lord.” Many spend years hoping and praying to one day perform the Hajj or saving up money and waiting for a permit to embark on the trip.

World Briefs

MONEY LAUNDERING CASE: NEPAL SC BARS ARREST OF EX-PM DEUBA, WIFE

KATHMANDU: Nepal's Supreme Court on Monday issued an interim order barring the arrest of former Prime Minister Sher Bahadur Deuba and his spouse Arzu Rana Deuba in a money laundering case. The bench, comprising Justice Mahesh Sharma Paudel and Nityananda Pandey, while hearing the plea filed by the couple, questioned the issuing of an arrest warrant by the Kathmandu District Court. The Kathmandu District Court had issued arrest warrants against Deuba and his wife on April 6, who had been abroad since February 26 seeking medical treatment. Last year, thousands of youths under the banner of the Gen Z group staged anti-govt protests in Kathmandu on September 8 and 9, in which 76 people were killed.

CHINA CONDEMNS BALOCHISTAN TRAIN BOMBING IN PAKISTAN

BEIJING: China on Monday condemned the bomb attack on a passenger train in Pakistan's restive Balochistan province that killed at least 24 people. Commenting on the attack, Chinese Foreign Ministry spokesperson Mao Ning expressed condolences to the victims and conveyed sympathies to the injured and the bereaved families. At least 24 people were killed and 50 others injured when a powerful explosion ripped through the shuttle train in Quetta, the capital city of Balochistan, on Sunday. The banned Balochistan Liberation Army (BLA) claimed responsibility for the blast.

EBOLA

Patients flee in attacks on Congo health facilities



BUNIA: Doctors operating on the front lines of the fight against Ebola in Congo, already grappling with shortages of basic supplies, are now also having to deal with attacks on their facilities and fleeing patients as the virus spreads rapidly.

At least three such incidents have occurred in the northeastern province of Ituri where the first Ebola cases were reported, including two at the weekend targeting the same hospital that permitted more than two dozen patients to run away.

The attacks recall the widespread violence targeting health facilities during a 2018-2020 outbreak in eastern Democratic Republic of Congo that killed more than 25 health workers.

Some were perpetrated by civilians who were angry about not being able to bury their loved ones or were convinced that the outbreak was a hoax. The influx of money and manpower into an area that had felt neglected during decades of conflict and humanitarian crisis has spurred local suspicions about the real motives for the sudden spike of interest.

A similar dynamic seems to be playing out now, said Dr Richard Lokodu, medical director of the Mongbwalu General Referral Hospital, which came under attack first on Saturday and again on Sunday.

"There is denial of the disease within the population, with some members wanting to claim the bodies of suspected and/or confirmed cases," he said.

The World Health Organization has declared the outbreak of the rare Bundibugyo strain of Ebola, the third-largest such outbreak on record, a public health emergency of international concern. AGENCIES

France bans Israeli minister Itamar Ben-Gvir

PARIS: France on Saturday banned Israel's far-right national security minister, Itamar Ben-Gvir, citing his "unspeakable" behaviour targeting activists from a flotilla to Gaza who were detained by his police force.

"As of today, Itamar Ben-Gvir is banned from entering French territory. This decision follows his unspeakable actions toward French and European citizens who were passengers on the Global Sumud Flotilla," the French foreign minister, Jean-Noël Barrot, announced in a post on X.

"We cannot tolerate that French nationals can be threatened, intimidated or brutalised in this way — all the more so by a public official," Barrot posted, calling on the European Union to also sanction Ben-Gvir.

The Associated Press has sought comment from Ben-Gvir's spokesperson and the office of Israeli PM Benjamin Netanyahu. AGENCIES

millenniumpost CLASSIFIEDS

CHANGE OF NAME

I, ANAMIKA CHATURVEDI W/o RAKESH CHATURVEDI R/o H.No-V-701, Street No-10, Vijay Park, Maujpur Delhi-110053. I have changed my name from ANAMIKA SHARMA to ANAMIKA CHATURVEDI. Henceforth I would be known by the name of ANAMIKA CHATURVEDI for all future purposes.

PUBLIC NOTICE

ICICI Bank

Branch Office: ICICI Bank Limited Plot No-23, Shal Tower, 3rd Floor, New Rohtak Road, Karol Bagh, New Delhi-110005

The following borrower(s) has/have defaulted in the repayment of principal and interest towards the Loan facility(ies) availed from ICICI Bank. The Loan(s) has/have been classified as Non-Performing Asset(s) (NPA). A Notice was issued to them under Section 13(2) of the Securitisation and Re-construction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act, 2002, at their last known addresses. However, it has not been served and are therefore being notified by way of this Public Notice.

Sr. No.	Name of the Borrower/ Co-Borrower/ Guarantor/ (Loan Account Number) & Address	Description of Secured Asset to be enforced	Date of Notice sent/ Outstanding as on Date of Notice	NPA Date
1.	Geeta Gaur/ Narsan Cables Private Limited/ Avinash Gaur/ TBDEL00006492954/ 34 D Block Sector 39 Noida Gautam Buddha Nagar Uttar Pradesh Noida- 201301	Lease Hold Plot Bearing No, 34, Block D, Sector 39, New Okhla Industrial Development Area, Gautam Buddha Nagar, Noida- 201301	07-05-2026 Rs. 9,51,044/-	03-02-2026
2.	Konika Chakraborty/ Subhra Chakraborty/ LBGUR00004637768/ House No. C-1/50, Madhu Vihar Delhi- 110059	Flat No. T2-2102 Block -D 21st Floor, Building Names As Unibera Towers Situated At Plot No. Gh-16F, Sector -1, Uttar Pradesh, Greater Noida (West)- 201307	07-05-2026 Rs. 28,89,341/-	05-03-2026
3.	Mohammed Usman/ Alnaved Exports Private Limited/ Mohd Meharban/ Rehana Baby/ Shabista/ LBDEL00002443561/ 8975 Naya Mohalla Pul Bangash, Azad Market Delhi- 110006	Cottage No. 8 & 9, Entire Basement & Ground Floor With Lawn (Without Roof Rights). With 60% Proportionate Undivided Share of Plot of Land Measuring 19,91.71 Sq Mtrs (proportionate Plot Area Comes To 551.826 Sq Mtrs). (Out of Cottage No 8 Having Its Area Measuring 500 Sq Yrds & Cottage No 9 Having Its Area Measuring 600 Sq Yrds) Being Part of Property No. 4, Known As 4/8 And 4/9, Situated At Raquet Court Road, Civil Lines, Delhi 110054	05-05-2026 Rs. 5,72,13,087.41/-	03-09-2025
4.	Pankaj Mittal/ Sanjay/ LBDEL00002094016/ Plot No 26 Ground Floor, Front Shakti Khand 3 Indrapuram, Ghaziabad Uttar Pradesh Ghaziabad - 201010	Flat No. B-19/4, 19th Floor, Tower B, "Himalaya Pride" Situated At Plot No.10 B, Techzone Iv, Greater Noida Uttar Pradesh 201307	05-05-2026 Rs. 33,54,425/-	03-02-2026
5.	Sanjay Kumar/ Shaibala Bhatti/ LBGH00005109263/ H-329 Green View Apartment, Sector 17h Vasundhra Uttar Pradesh Ghaziabad - 201012	House No.17-H/ 309, Second Floor, Without Roof Rights, Green View Heights, Sector 17h, Vasundhra Ghaziabad Uttar Pradesh 201001	05-05-2026 Rs. 11,22,397/-	08-02-2026
6.	Tarun Kumar Tripathi/ Anita Tripathi/ LBDEL00000661446/ C-164, Sec- C2 Kashmiri Enclave, Tronka City Loni Colony Uttar Pradesh Ghaziabad- 201001	Plot No. C-164, Sector-3, Kashmiri Enclave (Loni Housing), Tronica City, Ghaziabad Uttar Pradesh 200001	05-05-2026 Rs. 5,44,740/-	03-02-2026
7.	Vivek Chauhan/ Sheela Chauhan/ LBDEL00005882116/ LBDEL00004222711/ LBDEL00004222055/ LBDEL00004222054/ LBDEL00004222051/ P 24 Third Floor South Extension Part 2, Andrewsganj Delhi - 110049	Property Bearing No. 24 Entire Third Floor With Terrace Right (Except Pota Cabin Having An Area 6' X 4' on The Terrace of Third Floor For The First Floor Flat Only Permitted By The Local Authority) Block P, South Extn, Part II Delhi- 110049 (Along With One Car Parking on Lower Ground Floor)	25-04-2026/ Rs.6,25,012.01/- Rs.17,05,330.7/- Rs.51,13,260.01/- Rs.52,93,873.01/- Rs.47,21,114.51/-	03-09-2025

These steps are being taken for substituted service of Notice, The above borrower/s and/or guarantor/s (as applicable) is/are advised to make the outstanding payment within 60 days from the date of publishing this Notice. Else, further steps will be taken as per the provisions of the Securitisation and Re-construction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act, 2002.

Date: May 26, 2026
Place: Delhi/Ncr

Sincerely Authorised Officer,
For ICICI Bank Ltd.

कार्यालय कार्यपालन अभियंता, खारंग जल संसाधन संग्राम, विलासपुर (छ.ग.) जिला निरस्तीकरण आदेश

आदेश क्रमांक/ व.से.सि/ 2026

विलासपुर, दिनांक निविदा सूचना क्रं. 35/ व.से.सि/ 2025-26 दिनांक 25.03.2026 निविदा सिस्टम क्रं. 187675

(प्रथम आगमन) खारंग बाथी राट मुख्य नहर के पथखाल माईनर, जैतपुर माईनर, ओखर माईनर एवं खारपी झिड्डीझूझी में सी.सी.लाइनिंग का मरम्मत/नवीनीकरण एवं जैतपुर माईनर के आर.डी. 2640 मी. पर झी.आर.डी. का पुर्ननिर्माण एवं ओखर माईनर के आर.डी. 150 मी. व आर.डी. 380 मी. पर 02 नग फॉल का पुर्ननिर्माण एवं खारपी झिड्डीझूझी व ओखर माईनर के हेड रेगुलेटर का पुर्ननिर्माण कार्य राशि रुपये 264.17 लाख में एकल निविदाकार होने तथा प्रतिस्पर्धा के अभाव में निविदा निरस्त किया जाता है।

विज्ञापन क्रं. जी 252607422 / दिनांक 29.03.2026

G 262700964/3

कार्यपालन अभियंता, खारंग जल संसाधन संग्राम, विलासपुर (छ.ग.)

sd/-

Date : 19.05.2026

ASSETS CARE & RECONSTRUCTION ENTERPRISE LTD.

Place : GURUGRAM

AUTHORIZED OFFICER

TRUSTEE OF ACRE - 180 - TRUST

SYMBOLIC POSSESSION NOTICE

ICICI Bank

Branch Office: ICICI Bank Limited Plot No-23, Shal Tower, 3rd Floor, New Rohtak Road, Karol Bagh, New Delhi- 110005

The Authorised ICICI Bank Officer under the Securitisation, Reconstruction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act, 2002 and in exercise of the powers conferred under section 13(12) read with Rule 3 of the Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules 2002, issued Demand Notices to the borrower(s) mentioned below, to repay the amount mentioned in the Notice within 60 days from the date of receipt of the said Notice.

Having failed to repay the amount, the Notice is issued to the borrower and the public in general that the undersigned has taken symbolic possession of the property described below, by exercising powers conferred on him/her under Section 13(4) of the said Act read with Rule 8 of the said rules on the below-mentioned dates. The borrower in particular and the public in general are hereby cautioned not to deal with the property. Any dealings with the property will be subject to charges of ICICI Bank Limited.

Sr. No.	Name of the Borrower(s)/ Loan Account Number	Description of Property/ Date of Symbolic Possession	Date of Demand Notice/ Amount Demanded (Rs)	Name of Branch
1.	Satish Kumar Ranga-Deceased (Through His Legal Heir)/ Sunita Kumari Ranga/ LBDEL00005163121/ LBDAU00002257352	Flat No A-801, 8th Floor The People's Conservative Co-Operative Group Housing Society Ltd Situated At Plot No 10, Sector 18, Dwarka Delhi- 110045/ May 21, 2026	October 27, 2025 Rs. 31,21,220.27/-	Delhi NCR

The above-mentioned borrower(s)/guarantor(s) is/are hereby issued a 30 day Notice to repay the amount, else the mortgaged properties will be sold after 30 days from the date of publishing this Notice, as per the provisions under Rules 8 and 9 of Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules 2002.

Date: May 26, 2026
Place: Delhi/ NCR

Sincerely Authorised Officer,
For ICICI Bank Ltd.

ICICI Bank

Branch Office: ICICI Bank Ltd., Regional Office Jsel Building, Malviya Nagar JLN Marg-Jaipur- 302017

PUBLIC NOTICE-TENDER CUM E-AUCTION FOR SALE OF SECURED ASSET

[See proviso to Rule 8(6)]

Notice for sale of immovable asset(s)

E-Auction Sale Notice for the sale of immovable asset(s) under the Securitisation and Reconstruction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act, 2002 read with proviso to Rule 8 (6) of the Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules, 2002.

This notice is hereby given to the public in general and in particular to the Borrower(s) and Guarantor(s) that the below described immovable property mortgaged/ charged to the Secured Creditor, the Physical possession of which has been taken by the Authorised Officer of ICICI Bank Limited will be sold on 'As is where is', 'As is what is' and 'Whatever there is' as per the brief particulars given hereunder:

Sr. No.	Name of the Borrower(s)/ Co-Borrowers/ Guarantors/ Loan Account No.	Details of the Secured asset(s) with known encumbrances, if any	Amount Outstanding	Reserve Price Earnest Money Deposit	Date and Time of Property Inspection	Date & Time of E-Auction
(A)	(B)	(C)	(D)	(E)	(F)	(G)
1.	Kripa Shankar Sharma (Applicant) Rekha Sharma (Co-Applicant) A/c No. LBDAU00005692625, LBDAU00005692624	Unit No. S-3, 2nd Floor (Without Roof Rights), Plot No. C-36, Manglam City, Block- C, Village Hatholi, Kalwar Road, Jaipur, Rajasthan- 302012 Area- 750 Sq.ft.	Rs. 13,52,911/- as on May 18, 2026	Rs. 11,00,000/- From Rs. 1,10,000/-	June 03, 2026 From 11:00 A.M. to 02:00 P.M.	June 17, 2026 At 11:00 AM to 12:00 Noon

The online auction will be conducted on the website (URL Link- <https://BidDeal.in>). of our auction agency ValueTrust Capital Services Private Limited. The Mortgagors/ Noticees are given a last chance to pay the total dues with further interest by June 16, 2026 before 05:00 P.M. else the secured asset(s) will be sold as per schedule. The prospective bidders(s) must submit the Earnest Money Deposit (EMD) Demand Draft (DD) (Refer Column E) at ICICI Bank Ltd., Regional Office Jsel Building, Malviya Nagar JLN Marg-Jaipur- 302017 on or before June 16, 2026 before 05:00 P.M. Thereafter, they have to submit their offer through the website mentioned above on or before June 16, 2026 before 05:00 P.M. along with the scanned image of the Bank acknowledged DD towards proof of payment of EMD. In case the prospective bidder(s) is/ are unable to submit his/ her/ their offer through the website, then the signed copy of tender documents may be submitted at ICICI Bank Ltd. Regional Office Jsel Building, Malviya Nagar JLN Marg-Jaipur- 302017 on or before June 16, 2026 before 05:00 P.M. Earnest Money Deposit DD/P.O should be from a Nationalised/ Scheduled Bank in favour of "ICICI Bank Limited" payable at Jaipur.

For any further clarifications in terms of inspection, Terms and Conditions of the E-Auction or submission of tenders, contact ICICI Bank Employee Phone No. 9252097970.

Please note that Marketing agencies 1. ValueTrust Capital Services Private Limited, 2. Augeo Assets Management Private Limited, 3. Matex Net Pvt. Ltd., 4. Finvin Estate Deal Technologies Pvt Ltd., 5. Girnarsoft Pvt Ltd 6. Hecta Prop Tech Pvt Ltd., 7. Arca Emart Pvt Ltd., 8. Novel Asset Service Pvt Ltd., 9. Nobroker Technologies Solutions Pvt Ltd., 10. Navodayan Proptech Private Limited (XpertAR), have also been engaged for facilitating the sale of this property.

The Authorised Officer reserves the right to reject any or all the bids without furnishing any further reasons.

For detailed Terms and Conditions of the sale, please visit www.icicibank.com/n4p4s

Date: May 26, 2026
Place: New Delhi

Authorized Officer,
ICICI Bank Limited

PHYSICAL POSSESSION NOTICE

ICICI Bank

Branch Office: ICICI Bank Limited Plot No-23, Shal Tower, 3rd Floor, New Rohtak Road, Karol Bagh, New Delhi- 110005

The Authorised ICICI Bank Officer under the Securitisation, Reconstruction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act, 2002 and in exercise of the powers conferred under section 13(12) read with Rule 3 of the Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules 2002, issued Demand Notices to the borrower(s) mentioned below, to repay the amount mentioned in the Notice within 60 days from the date of receipt of the said Notice.

Having failed to repay the amount, the Notice is issued to the borrower and the public in general that the undersigned has taken possession of the property described below, by exercising powers conferred on him/her under Section 13(4) of the said Act read with Rule 8 of the said rules on the below-mentioned dates. The borrower in particular and the public in general are hereby cautioned not to deal with the property. Any dealings with the property will be subject to charges of ICICI Bank Limited.

Sr. No.	Name of the Borrower(s)/ Loan Account Number	Description of Property/ Date of Physical Possession	Date of Demand Notice/ Amount in Demand (Rs)	Name of Branch
1.	Samir Kishore Majithia/ Needhi Samir Majithia/ LBMUM00001810453	Flat No. 1938, 19th Floor, Osimo Mahgun, Moderne, Sector 78, Plot No. Gh-02, Noida 201301/ May 21, 2026	January 11, 2023 Rs. 57,22,075.00/-	Delhi/ NCR/ Mumbai

The above-mentioned borrower(s)/guarantor(s) is/are hereby issued a 30 day Notice to repay the amount, else the mortgaged properties will be sold after 30 days from the date of publishing this Notice, as per the provisions under Rules 8 and 9 of Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules 2002.

Date: May 26, 2026
Place: Delhi/Ncr

Sincerely Authorised Officer
For ICICI Bank Ltd.

NORTH CENTRAL RAILWAY

Tender Notice No.: AGC-ELG-T-11R-2025-26

Date: 25.05.2026

E-TENDER NOTICE

Sr. Divisional Electrical Engineer (General) N.C. Railway, Agra for and behalf of President of India invites "Open Tender" through on line only (E-Tendering) for the following works.

Name of work with its location & Completion Period: Various Repair/minor modification work in LHB Power Car, AC Coach & Non-AC Coaches at Agra Cantt Coaching Depot.

Completion Period: 06 months | **Approx. Cost of the work:** ₹ 1834892.23 (Including GST)

For full details and submission of bid please see the Indian Railways website www.ireps.gov.in Tenders can only be submitted through web portal www.ireps.gov.in upto 15:00 hrs on 16.06.2026. 1185/26(A)

f North central railways | @CPRONCR | www.ncr.indianrailways.gov.in

ASSETS CARE & RECONSTRUCTION ENTERPRISE LTD.

Corporate Office : Unit No. 502, C Wing, ONE BKC, Plot No. C - 66, G - Block, Bandra Kurla Complex, Mumbai - 400051. Tel : 022 68643101

Registered Office : 14th Floor, EROS Corporate Tower, Nehru Place, New Delhi - 110019.

E-mail : acre.ara@acreindia.in | **Website :** www.acreindia.in | **CIN :** U65993DL2002PLC115769

APPENDIX IV-A

Sale Notice for sale of Immovable Property

E-Auction Sale Notice for sale of Immovable Assets under the Securitisation and Reconstruction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act, 2002 read with proviso to Rule 8(6) and Rule 9(1) of the Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules, 2002.

Notice is hereby given to the public in general and in particular to the Borrower(s) and Guarantor(s) that the below described Immovable Property mortgaged to Assets Care & Reconstruction Enterprise Ltd. (ICIN : U65993DL2002PLC115769) ("Secured Creditor"), the constructive possession of which has been taken by the Authorised Officer of the Secured Creditor, will be sold on "as is where is", "as is what is" and "whatever there is" basis on 12.06.2026 from 05.00 P.M. to 06.00 P.M., for recovery of Rs. 30,46,062/- (Rupees Thirty Lakh Forty Six Thousand and Sixty Two only) pending towards Loan Account No. HHLGRG00260442, by way of outstanding principal, arrears (including accrued late charges) and interest till 06.05.2026 with applicable future interest in terms of the Loan Agreement and other related loan document(s) w. e. f. 07.05.2026 along with legal expenses and other charges due to the Secured Creditor from ROHIT JAGGI and REETU MALHOTRA. The Loan Account bearing No. HHLGRG00260442, along with all right(s), title(s), interest(s), underlying security(ies), pledge(s) and / or guarantee(s), including the Immovable Property, had been assigned by Sammaan Capital Limited ("SCL") (formerly known as Indiabulls Housing Finance Ltd.) to Indiabulls Asset Reconstruction Co. Ltd. ("IARCL") vide Assignment Agreement dated 31.12.2019 and the same had been renumbered by IARCL and bears new Loan Account No. R056XIL. The said Loan Account had been further assigned by IARCL to and in favour of the Secured Creditor, acting as a Trustee of ACRE - 102 - Trust vide Assignment Agreement dated 26.04.2021 read with Rectification Deed dated 26.08.2021. Furthermore, the said Loan Account has now been assigned by Assets Care & Reconstruction Enterprise Ltd. acting as a Trustee of ACRE - 102 - Trust to and in favour of the Secured Creditor acting as Trustee of ACRE - 180 - Trust vide Assignment Agreement dated 23.06.2025.

The Reserve Price for the Immovable Property will be Rs. 25,00,000/- (Rupees Twenty Five Lakh only) and the Earnest Money Deposit ("EMD") will be Rs. 2,50,000/- (Rupees Two Lakh Fifty Thousand only) i.e. equivalent to 10% of the Reserve Price.

DESCRIPTION OF THE IMMOVABLE PROPERTY

APARTMENT NO. C - 1007 HAVING CARPET AREA OF 535.40 SQ. FEET AND BALCONY AREA OF 61.35 SQ. FEET 10TH FLOOR IN TOWER - C IN PROJECT KNOWN AS "ROF AALYAS", SECTOR - 102, VILLAGE DHANKOT, GURUGRAM - 122001, HARYANA. ALONG WITH ONE (TWO - WHEELER) PARKING SPACE BEARING NO. OP- 128.

For detailed terms and conditions of the sale, please refer to the link provided on the website of the Secured Creditor i.e. www.acreindia.in; Contact No : 0124-6910910, +91 7065451024; E-mail id: auctionhelp@sammaanacp.com. For bidding, log on to www.auctionfocus.in.

sd/-

AUTHORIZED OFFICER

ASSETS CARE & RECONSTRUCTION ENTERPRISE LTD.

TRUSTEE OF ACRE - 180 - TRUST

Date : 19.05.2026

ASSETS CARE & RECONSTRUCTION ENTERPRISE LTD.

Place : GURUGRAM

Chhattisgarh State Industrial Development Corporation Limited
(A Government of Chhattisgarh Undertaking)
(ISO 9001 : 2015 Certified)
1st Floor, Udyog Bhawan, Ring Road No.1, Tolibandha, Raipur (C.G.) - 492006
CN : U45202CT1981S000183, PAN : AAACMC288N, GST Regn No:AAACMC688N52Y
Phone : 0771-6621000 Fax : 0771-2583794
Website : www.csidc.in, Email: address.csidc.cg@nic.in, csidc_raipur@yahoo.com

NOTICE INVITING TENDER (2nd Call)
(Through e-Procurement Portal Only)

No. : 17 /CSIDC/E.-I/Division-I/2026-27/ 191507 Raipur, dated 22/05/2026

Online (Percentage Basis) tenders in Form-A are invited from contractors registered in Class-B & Above in New Unified Registration System (E-Registration) website <https://eproc.cgstate.gov.in> at appropriate class, for the following works -

S.No.	Name of Work	Registered Contractor in CGPWD or in appropriate class in other dep't.	Time allowed including rainy season	Estimated Cost (INR Lacs)	EMD (INR Lacs)	Cost of Tender Doc. (INR) including GST 18%
1.	Construction of R.C.C Drain & R.C.C Hume pipe Culvert 1000mm dia for 18.0m &24.0m wide road at Industrial area Silphari Distt. Bilaspur (C.G.)	B & Above	06 Months i/c rainy season	442.73 Lacs	2,21,500/-	3540/-

The tender document and other details can be downloaded from the web portal (website) <https://eproc.cgstate.gov.in> from 22/05/2026 and shall be submitted online only. Amendment in tender, if any, will only be uploaded on the website and shall not be published in any newspaper.

NOTE:

- The interested tenderers for online submission of tender may contact CG eProc Helpdesk. Operated by JMunction Services Limited, they may reach Helpdesk using: 18002582502 (from 9 AM to 11 PM) (therein press 2 for CG e-Proc) or you can email them at helpdesk.eproc@cgswan.gov.in.
- Tenderer may contact to E.E., Div-I, CSIDC, Udyog Bhawan in working hours to clear their doubt if any before online submission of the tender

samvad 47922/3

Executive Engineer, Division-I

UNION TERRITORY OF JAMMU & KASHMIR

OFFICE THE SUPERINTENDING ENGINEER PWD (R&B) CIRCLE SOUTH JAMMU

TENDER NOTICE INVITING

e-NIT No.SESJ/08 of 2026-27 dated 22-05-2026.

For and on behalf of the Lt. Governor of Union Territory of J&K, e-tenders are invited on percentage rate basis from approved and eligible Contractors registered with Union Territory of J&K/CPWD / BRO/ Railways/ MES and other State/ Central Government for the work mentioned below:-

S.No	Name of Work	Advertised Cost	Cost of document (in Rs.)	Earnest Money Deposit in the form of CDR/ BG	Time Allowed for completion	Time and date of opening of tender	Class of Contractor
1	Construction/repair of lanes, roads, F/wall, Iron Grating and other allied works in different location of MC, Bishnah(Under Disaster Management Scheme (SASCI 2026-27).	Rs.476.56 lacs	6000/-	2% of the advertised cost Rs.953120/-	03 Months	At or after 1200 hrs on 08-06-2026	'A' Class

Position of AAA =Accorded.
Position of Tech. sanction = Accorded.

The bidding documents Consist of qualifying information, eligibility criteria, specifications, bill of quantities (B.O.Q), Set of terms and conditions of contract and other details can be seen/downloaded from the departmental website <http://jtenders.gov.in> as per below schedule:-

1	Date of Issue of Tender Notice	22.05.2026
2	Period of downloading of bidding documents	From 22.05.2026 to 06.06.2026, 1800 Hrs
3	Date, Time and place of pre-bid meeting	30.05.2026 at 1400 hrs in the Office of the Superintending Engineer, PWD (R&B) Circle South, Jammu
4	Bid submission Start Date	22.05.2026 From 1800 Hrs
5	Bid Submission End Date	06.06.2026 up to 1800 Hrs
6	Date & Time of opening of Technical Bids (Online)	08.06.2026 at 1200 hrs in the Office of the Superintending Engineer, PWD (R&B) Circle South, Jammu
7	Date & Time of opening of Financial Bids (Online)	To be notified after technical bid evaluation is completed

- Bids must be accompanied with cost of Tender document in shape of challan through Treasury indicating the name of work and e-NIT No. favouring Superintending Engineer, PWD (R&B) Circle South, Jammu by crediting to 0059-PWD (Revenue) issued after issuance of e-NIT No. & Date uploading a copy of treasury challan/ receipt issued after the advertisement of e-NIT. The date on challan should be between date of start of bid submission and bid submission end date.
- The date and time of opening of Financial-Bid shall be notified on Web Site [www.jtenders.gov.in](http://jtenders.gov.in) and conveyed to the bidders automatically through an e-mail message on their e-mail address. The Financial-bids of Responsive bidders shall be opened online in the Office of the Superintending Engineer, PWD (R&B) Circle South, Jammu. The date for same shall be intimated separately.
- The bids for the work shall remain valid for a period of 120 days from the date of opening of Technical bids.
- Instruction to bidders regarding e-tendering process:-
- Bidders are advised to download bid submission manual from the "Downloads" option as well as from "Bidders Manual Kit" on website www.jtenders.gov.in. in to acquaint bid submission process.
- 4.2. To participate in bidding process, bidders have to get 'Digital Signature Certificate (DSC)' as per Information Technology Act-2000. Bidders can get digital certificate from any approved vendors.
- 4.3. The bidders have to submit their bids online in electronic format with digital Signature. No financial bid will be accepted in physical form.
- 4.4. Bidders must ensure to upload scanned copy of all necessary documents mentioned in e-NIT and SBD as a part of technical bid.

Note:- Scan all the documents on 100 dpi with black and white option.

- The department will not be responsible for delay in online submission due to any reasons.
- EMD in shape of FDR/CDR/BG pledged to Superintending Engineer, PWD (R&B) Circle South, Jammu should be 2% of the advertised cost & must be uploaded with the bid. The CDR/FDR/BG shall be valid for 45 days beyond the bid validity period. The earnest money shall be forfeited if:
 - any bidder/tenderer withdraws his/bid/tender during the period of bid validity or makes any modifications in the terms and conditions of the bid.
 - Failure of successful bidder to furnish the required performance security within specified time period after issuance of letter of acceptance.
 - Failure of successful bidder to execute the agreement on same day of issuance of allotment of work.
- Performance Security/Additional performance security:- The successful bidder /contractor shall deliver to the Employer /concerned authority, a Performance Security in any of the required forms for the value of 3% of value of contract Within 07 (Seven) days after the date of receipt of the Letter of Acceptance, as per Circular of Worthy Principal Secretary to Government, Finance Department Civil Secretariat Jammu vide No.FD-Codes/441/2021-02-158 dated 08-08-2025 and Worthy Chief Engineer PWR(R&B) Department, Jammu's No.CEJ/Tech./J-ZMU/6645-65 dated 11-08-2025

No.-SESJ/DB/1736-43

Dated:-22.05-2026

DIP No:DIP/J-2633/26

sd/-

Superintending Engineer

PWD (R&B)Circle South Jammu

millenniumpost CLASSIFIEDS

IRFC hits all-time high profit, makes landmark Hyderabad Metro funding

IRFC recorded its best-ever PAT of Rs 7,009.17 crore during previous fiscal while its revenue was at an all-time high of Rs 27, 284.15 crore

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Indian Railways Finance Corporation Ltd (IRFC) announced its highest-ever performance during FY26 after making a historic Rs 13,527 crore refinancing arrangement for the Hyderabad Metro Rail Project. IRFC termed the move towards greater diversification within its infrastructure financing business from the traditional railway industry.

IRFC recorded its best-ever PAT of Rs 7,009.17 crore while its revenue was at an all-time high of Rs 27, 284.15 crore.

The net worth of IRFC was recorded at Rs 56,748.76 crore, while Assets under Management (AUM) stood at Rs 4.85 lakh crore, and total assets were at Rs 5.16 lakh crore. Further, the company retained its NIL NPA position and paid a dividend of Rs 2.10 per share, registering a growth of 31 per cent in FY25. EPS was at Rs 5.36.

IRFC, on Monday, signed a term loan agreement worth Rs 13,527 crore with L&T Metro Rail (Hyderabad) Limited (L&TMRHL) for refinancing the obligations under the Hyderabad Metro Rail project, which is considered to be one of the biggest refinancing



IRFC, on Monday, signed a term loan agreement worth Rs 13,527 crore with L&T Metro Rail (Hyderabad) Limited (L&TMRHL) for refinancing the obligations under the Hyderabad Metro Rail project

exercises in the urban transport space of India. This agreement was executed in the presence of IRFC chairman and managing director Manoj Kumar Dubey and the chief secretary of Telangana, K Ramakrishna Rao.

This refinancing comes in after the transfer of 100 per cent equity stake in L&TMRHL from Larsen & Toubro Limited to the Government of Telangana through HMRL. It means that the metro railway has now become a state-owned public mobility asset.

As per IRFC, this refinancing

ing would help them repay existing obligations, which include non-convertible debentures (NCDs), commercial papers, and term loans and will ensure a smooth exit for exiting creditors as well.

The Hyderabad Metro Rail Project Phase-I extend over 69.2 kilometres and covers three routes and 57 stations, and is one of the world's biggest metro rail projects to be undertaken by public-private partnership (PPP). The network presently serves more than five lakh passengers per day.

Highlights

» The net worth of IRFC was recorded at Rs 56,748.76 cr, while AUM stood at Rs 4.85 lakh cr & total assets were at Rs 5.16 lakh cr

» Further, the company retained its NIL NPA position and paid a dividend of Rs 2.10 per share

» This refinancing comes in after transfer of 100% equity stake in L&TMRHL from L&T to Govt of Telangana via HMRL

CMD of IRFC, Manoj Kumar Dubey, referred to the agreement as a "historic moment" and said that the deal was made "in a very short period of time."

"This is a game-changing agreement," he stated, giving his appreciation to the Telangana government for their coordination and cooperation in the process of concluding this transaction. Special mention was made by him of the Chief Secretary of Telangana, K. Ramakrishna Rao, for his "continued support and guidance."

According to Dubey, the deal marked the changing role of IRFC after it got its Navratna tag and indicated its increasing focus on metro rail funding. "After getting our Navratna tag, we have been asked to extend our scope of work from railway finance to metro rail funding too. Urban transport is very important for a nation like India that is experiencing very rapid urbanisation rates," he said.

Dubey further stated that the refinancing of Hyderabad Metro would contribute to the development of the current metro ecosystem and open new doors for expansion of the metro in Hyderabad, which, according to him, "is one of the biggest growth engines for India's GDP."

Dubey further praised Larsen & Toubro and said the company had made "something of a marvel in Hyderabad" and added that the metro project would be the benchmark in the history of PPP models in India.

The head of IRFC further stressed the importance of such deals, explaining that "we want to establish ourselves as a reliable domestic funding agency, channelling Indian savings into Indian infrastructure, on Indian terms."

OUR CORRESPONDENT

MUMBAI: Benchmark equity indices Sensex and Nifty surged over 1 per cent on Monday, driven by a sharp correction in crude oil prices and a rally in global markets amid improving sentiment surrounding the US-Iran negotiations.

An appreciating rupee against the US dollar and intense buying in banking and financial stocks also bolstered sentiment, traders said.

The 30-share BSE Sensex jumped 1,073.61 points, or 1.42 per cent, to settle at 76,488.96. During the day, it soared 1,143.72 points, or 1.51 per cent, to 76,559.07.

A total of 2,785 stocks advanced, while 1,535 declined and 211 remained unchanged on the BSE.

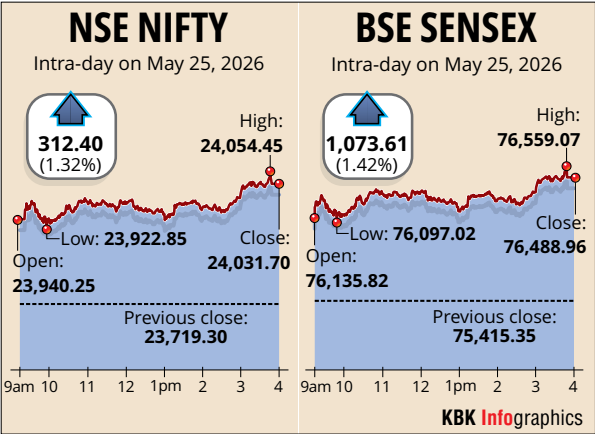
The 50-share NSE Nifty surged 312.40 points, or 1.32 per cent, to end at 24,031.70.

From the 30-Sensex firms, Bajaj Finance, Larsen & Toubro, HDFC Bank, Eternal, Bajaj Finserv, and Kotak Mahindra Bank were among the biggest winners.

In contrast, Infosys, Tata Consultancy Services, Sun Pharma and Hindustan Unilever were the laggards.

Brent crude, the global oil benchmark, tanked 5.52 per cent to \$97.82 per barrel.

The US has made significant progress in negotiations with Iran to reopen the Strait of Hormuz, but President Donald



A total of 2,785 stocks advanced, 1,535 declined and 211 remained unchanged on BSE

Trump is maintaining a cautious approach and will not accept a bad deal, Secretary of State Marco Rubio said on Monday.

"Markets witnessed strong positive momentum, driven by a correction in crude oil prices amid rising expectations of a potential US-Iran deal. Global sentiment improved on reports of progress towards reopening the Strait of Hormuz, although credibility remains uncertain given frequent shifts in developments," Vinod Nair, Head of Research, Geojit Investments Limited, said.

The BSE SmallCap Select

index jumped 1.18 per cent, and the MidCap Select index climbed 0.92 per cent.

Among sectoral indices, PSU Bank surged 2.96 per cent, Bankex (2.27 per cent), Top 10 Banks (2.19 per cent), Private Banks index (2.07 per cent), Financial Services (2.06 per cent), Telecommunication (1.89 per cent) and Auto (1.76 per cent).

On the other hand, FMCG and Hospitals were the laggards.

In Asian markets, Japan's Nikkei 225 index and Shanghai's SSE Composite index ended higher. Markets were closed in South Korea and Hong Kong due to holidays. European markets were trading higher. US markets ended in positive territory on Friday.

Foreign Institutional Investors (FIIs) offloaded equities worth Rs 4,440.47 crore on Friday, according to exchange data.

Rupee rises 34 paise to 95.26 against dollar



MUMBAI: The rupee appreciated 34 paise to close at 95.26 against the US dollar on Monday, registering the third straight session of gain, on optimism that the US and Iran were moving close to a peace deal even though they remained at odds over key issues, including blockades on the Strait of Hormuz.

The Indian rupee is not overvalued and may, in fact, be undervalued after its recent depreciation, the RBI governor said in an interview with Mint.

At the interbank foreign exchange market, the rupee opened at 95.36 against the US dollar, then touched an intraday high of 95.12 and a low of 95.44 during the trade.

At the end of Monday's trading session, the rupee was quoted at 95.26, higher by 34 paise from its previous close.

On Friday, the rupee rose 75 paise to close at 95.60 against the US dollar. Meanwhile, the dollar index, which gauges the greenback's strength against a basket of six currencies, was trading at 99.98, down 0.26 per cent.

Meanwhile, the country's forex reserves dropped \$8.094 billion to \$688.894 billion during the week ended May 15, the RBI said on Friday.

Braithwaite & Co organises TOLIC Meet and Hindi AI Tools workshop

KOLKATA: Braithwaite & Co. Ltd, Kolkata successfully organized the Second Executive Committee Meeting of the Town Official Language Implementation Committee (TOLIC) (Undertakings-2), Kolkata along with a training programme on "AI and IT Tools Available in Hindi" on May 21, 2026.

The programme was organised with the objective of promoting the effective implementation of Rajbhasha Hindi & making official work simpler and more qualitative through modern technological tools.

The programme was chaired by Sanjeev Rastogi, Director (Production), Braithwaite & Co. Ltd. On this occasion, Vichitrassen Gupta, Deputy Director (Implementation), Govt of India, attended as the

Chief Guest. Among those present were R Veera Bahu, Director (Finance), Braithwaite & Co. Ltd; P K Mishra, Executive Director (Human Resources, Operations & Services); Ajay Shankar Mishra, Member-Secretary, TOLIC (Undertakings-2), Kolkata; and Ravishankar Rajhans, Traffic Manager, Syama Prasad Mookerjee Port, Kolkata, along with officers from various member offices.

The training programme on "AI and IT Tools Available in Hindi" was conducted through video conferencing. Rajendra Verma, Joint Director, Hindi Teaching Scheme, Department of Official Language, Ministry of Home Affairs, Pune, participated as the expert speaker and provided detailed information re-garding the utility and practical applications of various AI and IT tools available in Hindi.

In his presidential address, Sanjeev Rastogi stated that in the present era of Artificial Intelligence and Information Technology, it is essential to technologically empower Hindi.

Chief Guest Vichitrassen Gupta highlighted the usefulness of modern AI and IT tools in the promotion and propagation of Rajbhasha Hindi and described them as highly beneficial for official work.

At the end of the programme, R Veera Bahu, Director (Finance), Braithwaite & Co. Ltd, expressed gratitude and delivered the vote of thanks to all the guests, participants, and member offices. The programme was conducted by Ajay Shankar Mishra and Deepak Kumar Thakur.

Adequate availability of fertilisers in country for upcoming Kharif sowing season: Govt

NEW DELHI: The Centre on Monday asserted that there is adequate availability of fertilisers in the country to meet the demand of soil nutrients during the upcoming Kharif (summer-sown) season.

At an inter-ministerial briefing on West Asia developments, Aparna S Sharma, Additional Secretary, Department of Fertilizers, said the domestic output post crisis has been good and the country is also importing fertilisers to ensure sufficient supply.

"The overall stock position of fertilizer in the country remains comfortable," she said.

As against the assessment of 390.54 lakh tonne for Kharif season this year, the stock as on date is 200.12 lakh tonne, the secretary said.

According to Sharma, the



fertilisers stock is more than 50 per cent of projected Kharif demand, significantly higher than the usual 33 per cent.

The Department of Agriculture has assessed the fertiliser requirement for Kharif 2026 at 390.54 lakh tonne.

The Kharif sowing operation will begin in June. Sharma also highlighted that the domestic production and import of fertilizers after the crisis has been substantial.

The total domestic produc-

tion has been about 95 lakh tonne and about 22.60 lakh tonne of imports have reached Indian shores.

So, a total of 117.6 lakh tonne fertilizers have been added to the stock.

The secretary said that the country has already secured 13.5 lakh tonne of DAP and 9 lakh tonne of NPK complexes. "This will ensure adequate availability during the peak Kharif season," Sharma said.

The secretary mentioned that the availability of inputs for the production of fertilizers also remains comfortable.

She informed that the Department of Fertilizer is regularly reviewing the situation.

The Empowered Group of Secretary has held nine meetings so far.

"The adequate availability

of finished fertilizers and raw materials is being reviewed. The position is stable and well managed," Sharma said.

In 2025, nearly 73 per cent of the country's total fertilizer requirement was met through domestic production.

Total domestic production of fertilizers, including Urea, DAP, NPKs and SSP has increased from 433.29 lakh tonne in 2021 to a record 524.62 lakh tonne in 2025.

India imports a large quantity of urea and diammonium phosphate (DAP) to meet local demand.

The country's urea production has increased from 225 lakh tonne during 2014-15 to 306.67 lakh tonne in 2024-25. The country imported more than 100 lakh tonne of urea last fiscal to meet local demand.

HZL's Rampura Agucha mine gets Zinc Mark certification

UDAIPUR: Hindustan Zinc Ltd (HZL) said its Rampura Agucha Mine has become India's first Zinc Mark-certified mine, marking a major milestone in responsible zinc production.

Rampura Agucha, the world's largest underground zinc-lead mine, received the certification under the globally recognised Zinc Mark assurance framework, which validates responsible production based on environmental, social and governance (ESG) standards, responsible sourcing and supply chain transparency.

The achievement follows Zinc Mark certification for the company's Chanderviya Smelting Complex, making Hindustan Zinc the first Indian company

to offer responsibly sourced zinc across the production chain from mining to smelting.

The certification was awarded after an independent third-party assessment under the Copper Mark Assurance Framework, verifying compliance with global responsible production standards.

CEO Arun Misra said the certification strengthens customer confidence in the company's transparent and sustainable production practices as global industries increasingly seek responsibly sourced metals. Hindustan Zinc supplies zinc to sectors including infrastructure, automobiles, renewable energy & electronics, where demand for low-carbon and ESG-compliant materials is rising.

PFRDA organises APY annual felicitation programme in Delhi

NEW DELHI: The Pension Fund Regulatory and Development Authority (PFRDA) on May 20, 2026 organised the APY Annual Felicitation Programme in New Delhi, recognising top performers under the Atal Pension Yojana (APY) for 2025-26.

Awards were presented to 53 APY service providers, 10 State Level Bankers' Committees (SLBCs), and leading branches and Lead District Managers.

Financial Services Secretary M Nagaraju said APY has crossed 9 crore gross enrolments, with assets under management (AUM) exceeding Rs 54,000 crore. A record 1.35 crore subscribers were added

APY has crossed 9 crore gross enrolments, with AUM exceeding Rs 54,000 crore

during 2025-26. He stressed the need to improve subscriber persistency, financial literacy and outreach in the urban informal sector.

PFRDA Chairperson S Ramann highlighted the growing importance of retirement planning and said APY recorded its highest-ever annual enrolment during the year. He noted rising partici-

pation among the 18-25 age group, indicating greater awareness about long-term financial security. PFRDA Whole Time Member Mamta Shankar said women's participation under APY touched a record 55.14 per cent in 2025-26.

As of May 18, 2026, total APY enrolments stood at 9.10 crore across all states and Union Territories.

Among banks, SBI, Union Bank of India and UCO Bank exceeded annual targets in the public sector category, while IDBI Bank led private banks. Jharkhand Rajya Gramin Bank and Tripura Gramin Bank topped the regional rural bank segment.

RBI caps UCB directors' continuous tenure at 10 yrs

MUMBAI: The RBI has barred individuals from serving continuously for over 10 years as directors on the boards of Urban Co-operative Banks (UCBs), introducing a mandatory three-year cooling-off period before reappointment.

The amended rules came into effect immediately through the RBI (Urban Co-operative Banks - Governance) Amendment Directions, 2026.

The RBI said some directors had been bypassing statutory provisions by briefly resigning and returning to the board through re-election or co-option, allowing them to extend their tenure beyond the

per-missible limit.

Under the revised norms, a director completing 10 continuous years on a UCB board can be reappointed only after a minimum three-year break. During the cooling-off period, the individual cannot be associated with the same UCB in any role other than as a member or customer.

The central bank clarified that the restriction will not prevent such individuals from joining the board of another bank, subject to eligibility conditions.

Similar governance directions have also been issued separately for Rural Co-operative Banks.

Banks seek hedging cost subsidy from RBI to raise dollar funding

The RBI met with treasury heads of large banks through last week, ahead of a monetary policy review on June 5

MUMBAI: Indian banks have sought subsidised forex hedging costs from the Reserve Bank of India to raise overseas borrowings, according to three sources, as the central bank seeks to shore up dollar inflows into the economy.

The central bank met with treasury heads of large banks through last week, ahead of a monetary policy review on June 5, where the suggestions were discussed, the sources who are familiar with the discussions, said.

Bankers at the meeting proposed a mechanism under which companies can hedge



dollar-denominated borrowings through lenders, while banks access lower-cost swaps from the central bank, according to the sources.

They suggested that this will help reduce the overall cost of raising overseas funds, Reuters reported.

CLOSER LOOK

» Bankers proposed a mechanism under which firms can hedge dollar-denominated borrowings through lenders, while banks access lower-cost swaps from central bank

» They suggested that this will help reduce the overall cost of raising overseas funds

"As per the latest discussions, the RBI is comfortable at bearing 150 basis points of the hedging cost, which should make the dollar borrowing cheaper than local fundraise, but some banks have requested for higher discounts," one of the sources said.

Bankers were of the view that such a subsidy could help raise up to \$50 billion, two of the sources said.

The sources requested anonymity as the matters are private, while the central bank did not respond to a Reuters email seeking comment.

Elevated crude oil prices and relentless outflows from Indian equities are likely to swing India's balance of payments to a large deficit this financial year, economists have warned.

The Indian rupee has been one of the worst performing Asian currencies so far in 2026, dropping as much as 4.7% against the dollar since the Iran war began.

India needs to take steps to improve its current and capital accounts, Reserve Bank of India Governor Sanjay Malhotra said in an interview with Mint newspaper on Monday.

Earlier this month Reuters had reported that the central bank is studying ways to mobilise dollar inflows - which could include deposits from non-resident Indians, a measure used in 2013 that garnered about \$26 billion - to stabilise the rupee.

The central bank had then allowed banks to swap dollars raised via such deposits at concessional rates.

India is considering several steps to counter the depreciation of the rupee, and New Delhi is monitoring the situation, trade minister Piyush Goyal said last week.

ONGC appoints BP to boost output from its western offshore fields

ONGC had engaged BP in January last year for Mumbai High, which accounts for 38% of ONGC’s western offshore oil & gas production

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: State-owned Oil and Natural Gas Corporation (ONGC) has appointed the UK’s BP as a technical services provider to boost output from its western offshore oil and gas fields, expanding a partnership aimed at reviving production from India’s ageing hydrocarbon assets.

In a statement, ONGC said BP Exploration Services India Limited was selected through an international competitive bidding process to enhance production across western offshore fields in the Mumbai Offshore Basin, excluding the flagship Mumbai High field.

ONGC had engaged BP in January last year for Mumbai High, India’s largest producing oil field, which accounts for about 38 per cent of ONGC’s western offshore oil and oil-equivalent gas production.

The company said preliminary results from the Mumbai High partnership showed moderation in production decline and improved output stability through better well, reservoir and facility management, along with infrastructure de-bottlenecking and enhanced surveillance.

Under the expanded mandate, BP’s India unit will assess



Preliminary results from the Mumbai High partnership showed moderation in production decline, the company said

reservoir performance and identify operational improvements across mature offshore fields using global technologies and management practices.

ONGC said the engagement could increase crude oil production by about 10.8 per cent over the 10-year contract period, raising output to 51.26 million tonnes (MT) from a baseline of 46.25 million tonnes. Natural gas production is projected to rise 31.5 per cent to 108.69 billion cubic metres from 82.68 bcm.

Combined oil and oil-equivalent gas production from

Highlights

» Under the expanded mandate, BP’s India unit will assess reservoir performance and identify operational improvements across mature offshore fields

» The engagement could raise crude oil output by about 10.8% to 51.26 MT over the 10-year contract period

» Natural gas output is estimated to rise 31.5% to 108.69 billion cubic metres from 82.68 bcm

the western offshore fields is expected to rise about 24 per cent to nearly 160 million tonnes of oil equivalent during the contract period, the company said.

The increase in production is expected to begin from fiscal year 2027, with full-scale impact visible from FY30.

Under the agreement, the technical services provider will receive a fixed fee for the first two years, followed by a share of revenue generated from incremental hydrocarbon production after cost recovery.

Separately, BP said it “can

confirm that it has been selected by ONGC as TSP for Western Offshore fields (excluding Mumbai High).”

“We are grateful to ONGC for once again reaffirming their trust in us and look forward to supporting an enhanced production from these fields,” it added.

ONGC, which accounts for about 75 per cent of India’s domestic crude oil and natural gas production, said the partnership is aimed at unlocking additional output from mature offshore assets while supporting India’s energy security goals amid rising demand.

Mumbai Offshore Basin is ONGC’s most prolific hydrocarbon-producing basin. The basin comprises 43 blocks, of which 28 blocks, including Mumbai High and the giant Bassein gas field, were given to it on a nomination basis.

“While ONGC continues to unlock new hydrocarbon resources through greenfield projects, enhancing recovery from mature fields remains equally important to raising domestic production,” the statement said.

ONGC said it entered into a Technical Services Provider (TSP) Contract with BP Exploration Alpha Ltd (BPXA) for the Mumbai High field, which is the

largest oil field of the Mumbai Offshore Basin, in early January 2025.

“Preliminary production data during the initial months of TSP implementation indicate moderation of the earlier decline trajectory and stabilisation of production. This has been achieved through focused well, reservoir and facility management (WRFM) initiatives, optimisation of existing wells, enhanced surveillance, and prioritised facility de-bottlenecking,” it said.

Building on this experience, ONGC decided to engage a TSP for the entire Western Offshore (excluding the Mumbai High field) in line with the existing TSP engaged for the Mumbai High field.

“Accordingly, ONGC issued an international competitive bidding (ICB) tender for engagement of a TSP to enhance production from mature offshore oil and gas fields in the Mumbai Offshore Basin (excluding Mumbai High) through the induction of global technology, expertise, and best-in-class operational and management practices. All the major international oil companies were invited to participate,” the statement said.

It, however, did not say how many participated in the tender.

Early offshore findings in Andaman show hydrocarbon potential: Lt Guv

Joshi said there is growing optimism about the basin’s long-term potential, with some estimates likening it to large global discoveries

SRI VIJAYA PURAM: Andaman and Nicobar Islands Lieutenant Governor D K Joshi on Monday said the offshore oil exploration in the archipelago has gained momentum after decades of inactivity, with early findings indicating promising hydrocarbon potential.

He said the recent exploratory drilling in the Andaman Basin has generated optimism.

“At the Sri Vijaya Puram-2 exploratory well, drilling by Oil India Ltd (OIL) has indicated a gas find with around 87 per cent methane content, alongside another zone with a high probability of crude oil presence. Data validation and commercial viability assessments are currently underway,” he said.

“The Andaman Basin has attracted strong interest ahead of upcoming auction rounds for oil blocks, with several global energy majors in discussions with the ONGC and the OIL for potential joint ventures. These collaborations are expected to bring in not just investment, but also advanced technology and specialised equipment required for deep-sea exploration in the region,” Joshi added.

Highlighting the untapped potential of the region, the lieutenant governor noted that despite accounting for nearly one-third of India’s Exclusive Economic Zone and over a quarter of its coastline, offshore exploration had remained largely absent for the first six to seven decades after Independence, as surrounding waters were designated “no-go zones”. The issue was subsequently

taken up with the Islands Development Agency, paving the way for exploration activities.

Joshi said there is growing optimism about the basin’s long-term potential, with some estimates likening it to large global discoveries, making it a “space to watch” in India’s energy landscape. In the hospitality sector, the lieutenant governor said the administration has awarded four major projects to firms under the public-private partnership (PPP) model.

“The response from investors has been strong, and even greater interest is being shown for upcoming projects,” he said.

Joshi said the administration is expanding helicopter services to further strengthen inter-island connectivity.

Alongside augmenting the Pawan Hans fleet, expressions of interest have been floated for private operators to run licensed routes, drawing significant industry response, he said.

“With 836 pristine islands, tourism holds immense potential, and improving connectivity has been prioritised. Seaplane operations have completed trial runs and, in the first phase, will connect Sri Vijaya Puram with

Long Island, Swaraj Dweep, Shaheed Dweep and Little Andaman. The administration aims to develop the region into a major seaplane hub for the Indian Ocean, and eventually the wider Indo-Pacific region,” he said. Highlighting the islands’ natural strengths, the lieutenant governor said the region has vast potential for scuba diving and underwater tourism.

Plans are afoot to position the Andaman and Nicobar Islands as a premier scuba diving destination in the Indo-Pacific region, Joshi said.

On the power front, he outlined a major transition towards clean and sustainable energy.

“A decade ago, nearly 90 per cent of the islands’ power generation relied on diesel, with only about 10 per cent coming from renewable sources such as solar and limited hydroelectric capacity. However, over the past 10 years, the share of diesel has reduced to around 70 per cent, while solar energy has increased to approximately 25 per cent,” he said.

Looking ahead, the administration aims to cut diesel dependence to single digits -- around 8 per cent -- within the next three years. Solar power is projected to rise sharply to 70 per cent, with around 18 per cent of energy needs expected to be met through LNG-based generation, Joshi said. He said proposals are also under examination for a high-voltage direct current (HVDC) undersea cable to connect the islands with the mainland grid, enabling greater energy stability.

Losses of oil PSUs fall to ₹600 cr/day following fuel price hikes



NEW DELHI: The four rounds of fuel price hike, totalling about Rs 7.5 per litre, have trimmed the losses state-owned oil firms were incurring from selling fuel below cost to close to Rs 600 crore per day, Sujata Sharma, Joint Secretary in the Ministry of Petroleum and Natural Gas, said on Monday.

The losses on sale of petrol, diesel and domestic cooking gas LPG were about Rs 1,000 crore per day before the start of the May 15 cycle of price revision. “It (losses) is slightly less than Rs 600 crore per day,” she said.

These losses include those from the sale of domestic LPG as well. LPG sold to domestic households is a subsidised product, and the difference between the cost and retail selling price is made good by the government.

Petrol and diesel, on the other hand, are deregulated products whose pricing is market-determined. The losses on these products accumulated after state-owned oil companies kept retail rates frozen despite the war in Iran pushing up input crude oil prices by over 50 per cent.

FM says unimaginable rise in global fertiliser prices, seeks focus on ‘3Fs’

MUMBAI: Union Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman on Monday said that there has been an unimaginable jump in the global fertiliser prices after the West Asia crisis.

Echoing Prime Minister Narendra Modi’s austerity call, she asked people to focus on ‘3Fs’ — fuel, fertiliser and forex — in the current scenario.

Speaking at the 37th foundation day event of Sidbi here, the finance minister said the West Asia crisis is not just a diplomatic or geopolitical issue, but it is also leading to a far-reaching impact on the common people and small businesses, and also becoming a challenge for countries, including India.

The crisis, which started with the US-Israel joint attack on Iran in late February, has

‘The crisis, which started with the US-Israel joint attack on Iran in late February, has continued for 80-90 days and led to an impact on commodity prices’

continued for 80-90 days and led to an impact on commodity prices, Sitharaman said.

The crude prices have been high and fluctuating for nearly three months since the conflict began, while the fertiliser prices are also elevated.

There has been an “unimaginable increase” in the fertiliser

prices, she said.

The minister said that gold prices have also gone high, and explained that purchasing the precious metal leads to a reduction in the country’s foreign exchange reserves.

This makes it very important to focus on the 3Fs of fuel, fertiliser, and forex in the current context, she said.

“The West Asia crisis is not only a diplomatic or geopolitical issue. For businesses and common people, it can mean higher fuel costs, delayed cargo, costlier shipping, shortage of inputs, pressure on working capital and uncertainty in export orders,” the finance minister said, adding that so many uncertainties are leading to challenges in business planning for small enterprises.

‘Govt forgone over ₹1 lakh crore via excise duty cuts to shield consumers from fuel inflation’

MUMBAI: Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman on Monday said the government had forgone more than Rs 1 lakh crore annually in tax revenues through excise duty cuts on petrol and diesel to shield consumers from fuel inflation triggered by the West Asia conflict, while defending the latest retail fuel price hikes as market-driven revisions by oil marketing companies responding to soaring global crude oil prices.

Petrol and diesel prices have been hiked by almost Rs 7.5 per litre in four installments since mid-May as oil companies moved to bridge the gap between cost and retail price that had widened due to surge in international oil prices.

“The increases now are coming from oil marketing companies (OMCs) because they



Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman

are the ones procuring (raw material crude oil) and selling (finished product - fuel),” Sitharaman said on the sidelines of the Cotton Textiles Export Promotion Council export awards event.

She said had the excise duty not been slashed earlier, an increase of Rs 10 would have happened. “Had we not given that reduction at that time, a Rs 10 increase would have happened, which we absorbed, that

“HAD THE EXCISE DUTY NOT BEEN SLASHED EARLIER, AN INCREASE OF RS 10 WOULD HAVE HAPPENED”

is almost a Rs 1 lakh crore hit on the functional budget. But the increases now are coming from OMCs, because they are the ones procuring and selling,” the minister added.

When asked if the RBI’s dividend of Rs 2.87 lakh crore aligned with the government’s expectations, especially given the current need for support, the minister stated that the calculations follow a very clear formulation.

“A committee had looked into it, and based on that RBI does its annual calculation and gives the dividend to the government. And it is on that basis it has come. I fully trust the RBI in having made its calculation and given the dividend that it has given,” she added.

On managing the oil price rise amid global challenges she said the situation will be closely monitored.

“These increase in prices are not minor, all this will have to be paid through foreign exchange only. So, these are going to be challenges, but I’m confident...we will be able to handle those challenges which are not of our making. If crude oil prices are growing, we will have to constantly monitor this, but make sure that people are not going to suffer,” she added.

Paytm arm to invest €9 mn in European subsidiary

NEW DELHI: Fintech firm One 97 Communications, which operates under the Paytm brand, on Monday said its wholly-owned subsidiary Paytm Cloud Technologies will invest 9 million euro in its European payment entity.

“...The Board of Directors of PCTL (Paytm Cloud Technologies Limited)...has approved an additional investment by way of subscription to 9 million equity shares of EUR 1 (one euro only) each at a total consideration of EUR 9 million (nine million euro), in its wholly-owned subsidiary, Paytm Europe Payments S.A (Paytm Europe),” the company said in a filing.

The transaction is aimed at

increasing the paid-up capital of Paytm Europe to support the funding requirements for its business. The transaction is expected to be completed on or before June 30, 2026, the company said.

Paytm Europe Payments S.A., incorporated in Luxembourg on January 12, 2026, is a step-down wholly-owned subsidiary of One 97 Communications. It is yet to commence its business operations. PCTL presently holds 100 per cent of the euro 1 million paid-up share capital of Paytm Europe.

Following the completion of this additional investment, there will be no change in the shareholding pattern, the filing added.

Elevated energy prices to weigh on near-term credit conditions of Indian cos, says Moody’s

NEW DELHI: Moody’s Ratings on Monday said elevated energy prices will weigh on the near-term credit conditions of Indian corporates, despite robust balance sheets and favourable long-term growth prospects.

Stating that Indian corporates are currently in a better financial position to absorb external shocks, supported by deleveraging, healthy liquidity and supportive policy frameworks, Moody’s said persistently high energy prices and structural shifts in key service industries could test credit strength over the coming quarters.

“Elevated energy prices weigh on near-term credit conditions for Indian corporates, despite strong fundamentals,”

The conflict in the Middle East will weigh on near-term earnings and cash flows for energy-intensive and fuel-dependent sectors

it said in a statement.

The conflict in the Middle East will weigh on near-term earnings and cash flows for energy-intensive and fuel-dependent sectors, it added.

“India’s heavy reliance on imported crude oil, liquefied natural gas and certain petroleum products exposes cor-

porates to higher input costs, currency volatility and supply chain disruptions.

“State-owned oil marketing companies and downstream fuel retailers face acute margin pressure as elevated costs are only partially passed through to consumers, while fuel-intensive sectors such as cement, chemicals, fertilisers and aviation are seeing rising cost burdens,” Moody’s Ratings Managing Director Vikash Halan said.

Moody’s Ratings India affiliate ICRA expects the operating environment for corporate India in FY2026-27 to be shaped by heightened geopolitical risks, particularly the ongoing tensions in the Middle East and evolving trade tariff develop-

ments with the US.

Against this backdrop, ICRA has revised the outlook to negative for aviation, fertilisers, and the refining and marketing segment within oil and gas.

Noting that not all sectors face headwinds, ICRA said that sustained improvement in order books has driven a positive outlook for capital goods and defence, while healthcare maintains a favourable position as demand for medical treatments and preventive services continues to rise. Weather-related risks present an additional layer of uncertainty. El Niño-like conditions could disrupt monsoon distribution, weighing on rural incomes & discretionary spending, it added.

Venture investments halve to \$2.7 bn in April on depreciation in rupee

MUMBAI: Venture capital and private equity investments fell sharply in April 2026 as rupee depreciation and geopolitical tensions hurt investor sentiment, according to a report by IVCA and EY released on Monday.

PE/VC funds invested \$2.7 billion across 83 deals during the month, nearly 50 per cent lower than both April 2025 and March 2026.

The number of transactions also dropped to a 29-month low from 134 deals a year earlier and 131 deals in March.

EY Partner Vivek Soni said the rupee’s deprecia-

tion to around Rs 96 against the US dollar, along with elevated crude oil and gas prices amid geopolitical tensions, has dampened foreign investor sentiment.

The report said investors remain cautious due to a wide gap between seller expectations and investor valuations. PE and VC funds are also slowing deployment of available capital until there is greater clarity on economic momentum and valuation corrections.

Despite near-term caution, the medium- and long-term outlook for India remains positive because of strong macroeconomic fundamen-

tals and long-term growth prospects, Soni said.

The largest transaction in April was ICICI Prudential Alternatives’ \$283 million investment in two RMZ office assets in Bengaluru and Pune.

The month saw nine large deals worth a combined \$1.7 billion.

Real estate attracted the highest investments at \$699 million, followed by financial services at \$440 million and technology at \$361 million.

Fundraising during the month stood at \$646 million across six deals, the lowest since December 2024.

NBCC Q4 PAT jumps 60.41% to ₹220.06 crore

NEW DELHI: NBCC (India) Limited on Monday reported strong growth in profit for the January-March quarter and the full financial year 2025-26.

On a standalone basis, total income in Q4 FY26 rose 21.61 per cent to Rs 3965.05 crore from Rs 3260.54 crore in Q4 FY25.

Profit before tax (PBT) increased 57.51 per cent to Rs 293.34 crore, while profit after tax (PAT) climbed 60.41 per cent to Rs 220.06 crore from Rs 137.19 crore a year earlier.

On a consolidated basis, Q4 total income stood at Rs 4618.60 crore against Rs 4700.86 crore in Q4 FY25.

PBT rose 37.44 per cent to Rs 342.29 crore, while PAT increased 38.78 per cent to Rs 253.51 crore.

For full financial year 2025-26, standalone total income grew 12.43 per cent to Rs 10055.45 crore. PAT rose 47.72 per cent to Rs 703.29 crore.

Consolidated total income increased 7.52 per cent to Rs 13195.89 crore, while PAT climbed 33.19 per cent to Rs 742.45 crore.

The company secured business worth Rs 18,780 crore on a consolidated basis during FY26. The company’s consolidated order book stood at Rs 1,27,820 crore as on March 31, 2026.

Peaking in the hills

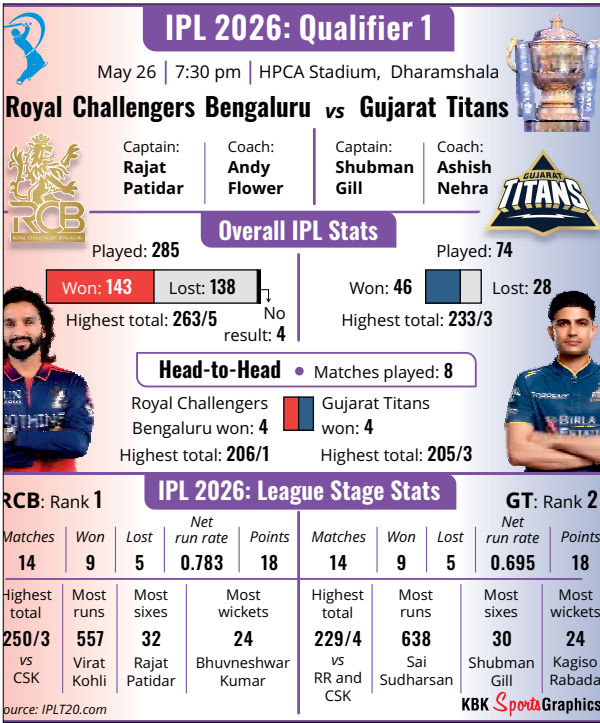
Qualifier 1: RCB's batting depth vs GT's relentless bowling machine

DHARAMSHALA: Royal Challengers Bengaluru's pursuit of back-to-back Indian Premier League (IPL) titles will run into the season's most disciplined bowling attack when they face Gujarat Titans in Qualifier 1 here on Tuesday, with a direct place in the final at stake.

Both teams ended the league stage on 18 points after 14 matches, but RCB claimed the top spot owing to a superior net run rate.

Royal Challengers Bengaluru and Gujarat Titans have arguably been the two most complete sides of IPL 2026, though they have taken contrasting routes to the playoffs. RCB, under skipper Rajat Patidar, built their campaign around aggressive batting and a far more reliable bowling unit than in previous seasons.

The defending champions repeatedly crossed 200 this season and benefited immensely from the experience of the iconic Virat Kohli at the top and the pace duo of Josh Hazlewood and Bhuvneshwar Kumar with the ball. Their ability to win away from home and close out tight matches made them one of the most consistent sides of the league phase. RCB also carry the advantage of recent familiarity with conditions in



Dharamshala, where they sealed a crucial win against Punjab Kings earlier this month.

GT, meanwhile, have surged into the playoffs on the back of a formidable bowling attack and a top order that rarely allowed pressure to build. Captain Shubman Gill, the elegant Sai Sudharsan and

explosive wicketkeeper-batter Jos Buttler have provided solidity and firepower in equal measure.

But it is GT's bowling that has stood out in the second half of the season. The pace trio of Mohammed Siraj, Kagiso Rabada and Prasidh Krishna has consistently struck with

7
RCB have won each of the seven games where Kohli has batted beyond the powerplay

the new ball, while Rashid Khan and left-arm spinner R Sai Kishore have controlled the middle overs expertly.

GT head into the knockout clash with strong momentum after hammering Chennai Super Kings by 89 runs in their final league game.

The contest could eventually hinge on a handful of key match-ups. Kohli against Protea pace ace Rabada promises to be one of the defining battles of the evening, especially with the extra bounce available in Dharamshala. Kohli's ability to negotiate the early burst from GT's quicks could shape RCB's powerplay. Similarly, Phil Salt's attacking intent against Siraj, who knows the RCB setup intimately after previous seasons with the franchise, could dictate the early tempo.

Dharamshala factor

DHARAMSALA: The evidence from the three IPL matches played in Dharamshala this season suggests that it has evolved into a high-scoring venue where fast bowlers still remain relevant, a combination that could shape Tuesday's Qualifier 1 between Royal Challengers Bengaluru and Gujarat Titans.

The numbers tell the story clearly. Across the three completed matches at the HPCA Stadium this season, every first-innings total has either touched or crossed 200.

So while Dharamshala continues to offer seam movement and bounce, the old perception of it being a purely bowler-friendly venue no longer fully applies. The true carry has created conditions where batters can dominate once they survive the opening overs.

What remains unique, however, is how the ball behaves early in the innings.

PARIS: At age 39, Novak Djokovic can still wear opponents down.

Even opponents nearly half his age — and in front of a hostile crowd.

Djokovic came back from a set down for a 5-7 7-5 6-1 6-4 victory over 22-year-old home player Giovanni Mpetshi Perricard in the first round of the French Open on Sunday in his record 82nd Grand Slam appearance.

"Obviously playing a French player, centre court at Roland Garros is never so easy. The crowd gets into it and then you feel the pressure even more," Djokovic said after the 2 hour, 51-minute encounter.

"But all in all it was a good match to be part of: Three hours, just what the doctor ordered at age 39."

Grunting during long rallies and digging deep on the opening night session on Court Philippe-Chatrier, it wasn't until 1 hour, 45 minutes in that Djokovic finally found a way to break his 6-foot-7 (2.01-meter) opponent and even the match at a set all. The crowd was pumped for a potential stunner — after all, Djokovic hasn't lost in the first round of a Grand Slam in 20 years. But after two tense sets, Mpetshi Perricard seemed deflated of



Novak Djokovic celebrates after beating Giovanni Mpetshi Perricard

Swiatek required exactly one hour to eliminate 136th-ranked Emerson Jones 6-1 6-2

energy.

Swiatek grounded

It was a massive mismatch on paper and that's the way it ended up on court, too. Four-time champion Iga Swiatek required exactly one hour to eliminate 136th-ranked debutante Emerson Jones 6-1, 6-2 in the first round on Monday, in front of a mostly empty Court Philippe-Chatrier on another steamy day in Paris.

The only real issue for the third-ranked Swiatek came

when she needed a trainer to re-tape the middle finger on her tennis-playing right hand for an apparent blister after the first set. "I'm just really happy to play on this court," she said. "First matches are always also for getting used to the condition tactically and type of the ball."

Swiatek has not won a title on clay this season and recently made a coaching change. She hired Francisco Roig, who previously worked with record 14-time French Open champion Rafael Nadal. "Nothing comes easy," Swiatek said. "With more titles it's even a bit harder because everyone expects you to be ready always and play perfectly. So you need to stay humble and not take anything for granted."

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POSSESSION NOTICE (For Immovable Property)
[Under Rule 8(1) of Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules, 2002]

Whereas, the undersigned being the Authorized Officer of the Central Bank of India, Okhla Industrial Estate Branch, New Delhi under the Securitization and Reconstruction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest (Act) 2002 and in exercise of powers conferred under Section 13(12) and 13(2) read with Rule 3 of the Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules, 2002 issued a Demand Notice dated 02.01.2026, Calling upon the Borrower: **MRS. SEEMA NAGI W/O LATE RAJESH NAGI AND ALL LEGAL HEIRS OF LATE SH. RAJESH NAGI**, to repay the amount mentioned in the notice being **Rs.17,94,007/- (Rupees Seventeen Lakh Ninety Four Thousand and Seven Only)** (which represents the principal plus interest due as on the 02.01.2026), plus interest and other charges from 03.01.2026 to till date within 60 days from the date of receipt of the said notice. The borrower having failed to repay the entire dues of the bank, notice is hereby given to the borrower, the Guarantor and the public in general that the undersigned has taken possession of the property described herein below in exercise of powers conferred on him/her under Section 13(4) of the said Act read with Rule 8 of the Security Interest (Enforcement) Rule 2002 on this 20th Day of May 2026.

The borrower and the Guarantor in particular and the public in general is hereby cautioned not to deal with the property and any dealing with the property will be subject to the charge of the Central Bank of India, Okhla Industrial Estate Branch, New Delhi for **Rs.17,94,007/- (Rupees Seventeen Lakh Ninety Four Thousand and Seven Only)**, plus interest and other charges from 03.01.2026 to till date.

The borrower's attention is invited to provisions of sub-section (8) of section (13) of the SARFAESI Act, in respect of the time available, to redeem the secured assets.

DESCRIPTION OF THE IMMOVABLE PROPERTY
Flat No.302, Third Floor, Without Roof Rights Back Side, Plot No.RZ-H-2/64-A, Khasra No.79/24, Village - Palam, Mahavir Enclave Colony, New Delhi-110045. Bounded By:

North: Road South: Gali
East: RZ/H/64-Laxmi Niwas West: RZ/H/65 Rajiv Ranjan

PLACE: NEW DELHI (Authorised Officer),
DATE: 20/05/2026 Central Bank of India

NORTHERN RAILWAY
Invitation of Tenders through E-Procurement System
Principal Chief Materials Manager, Northern Railway, New Delhi-110001, for and on behalf of the President of India, invites e-tenders through e-procurement system for supply of the following items:-

S. No.	Tender No.	Brief Description	Qty.	Closing Date
01	82255077	ROBOTIC SURGERY SYSTEM (AS PER ATTACHED SPECIFICATION)	01 No.	30.06.2026

Pre-Bid Meeting to be held on 12.06.2026 (03:00 PM) at Room No. 35, Conference Hall, SAMVAD, Northern Railway, Central Hospital, P K Road, New Delhi-110055.

Note:- 1. Vendors may visit the IREPS website i.e. www.ireps.gov.in for details. 2. No manual offer will be entertained.

Tender Notice No.: 82255077 Dated: 25.05.2026 1762/2026

SERVING CUSTOMERS WITH A SMILE

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF A PERSON ACCUSED
See Section 82 Cr. P.C. / 84 BNSS
Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused person **Vikash S/o Raj Kumar R/o H. No. 132, Chhoti Metro Vihar, Delhi** has Committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in case **FIR No. 366/2019 U/s 25/54/59 Arms Act, P.S. Narela Industrial Area, Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused **Vikash** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused **Vikash** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant).
Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused **Vikash** of case **FIR No. 366/2019 U/s 25/54/59 Arms Act, P.S. Narela Industrial Area, Delhi** is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on or before **30.06.2026**.

By Order
Ms. Jyoti Nain
Judicial Magistrate First Class
Court No. 06
Rohini Courts, Delhi

DP/6312/ON/2026 (Court Matter)

MISSING CAPITAL GAINS DC let crucial moments slip away, says Badani

KOLKATA: Delhi Capitals head coach Hemang Badani admitted that his side failed to produce consistent performances through the season and paid the price for not capitalising on key moments in crucial matches.

DC ended their 2026 IPL campaign in sixth place with seven wins and as many defeats, falling short of the playoffs for the fifth year running.

There were several matches where DC came close to winning but failed to cross the line. They suffered a heartbreaking one-run defeat against Gujarat Titans at home and were also unable to defend a massive total of 264 against Punjab Kings. To



Axar Patel and Co ended their campaign placed sixth

add to their woes, there were dropped catches galore which proved to be decisive in their losses against Chennai Super Kings and Sunrisers Hyder-

abad. "There were many games that I genuinely felt that could go either way. And we did not seize those moments," Badani said.

NORTHERN RAILWAY CORRIGENDUM
Ref: i) Tender Notice No. 05/2026-2027 dated 21.04.2026.
ii) Tender No. 08260001A due on 04.06.2026.
01. In reference to above tender, the due date has been extended from 25.05.2026 to 04.06.2026.
02. In reference to above tender eligibility criteria has been revised. All other terms & conditions remain unchanged. The Corrigendum has been published on website www.ireps.gov.in. 1769/2026

NORTH CENTRAL RAILWAY
No.:JHS/W/T/Tender General/124 Date : 22.05.2026
E-Tender Notice
Divisional Railway Manager (Works) N.C. Railway, Jhansi for and behalf of President of India invites sealed "Open Tender" through on Line (E-Tendering) for the following work.
E-Tender No.: JHS-ENG-G-2026-124. **Description of work:** Jhansi - Sithouli - Rock fall protection, slope stabilization and other ancillary work to protect the rock falling.
Approx. Cost: ₹ 20,24,04,132.09 **Earnest Money :** ₹ 40,48,100.00
Date of closing Tender : 15.06.2026 at 15:00 hrs.
Date of completion/period from issue acceptance letter: 12 Months
Tender online can be submitted up to 15:00 hrs on 15.06.2026 For full details and submission of bid please see the Indian Railways website www.ireps.gov.in 1178/26 (MG)
North central railways @CPRONCR www.ncr.indianrailways.gov.in

JHARKHAND FLYING INSTITUTE
State Hangar, Birsa Munda Airport, Hinoo Ranchi-834002
E-mail-jfi@jharkhandaviation.in,
Website-www.jharkhandaviation.in
Ref. No.: JFI / Employment-25/2025-429 /Ranchi, Dated:-23.05.2026
Notice
Jharkhand Flying Institute (JFI) invites application from qualified and experienced candidates for Technical/ Non-Technical Post for FTO.
Please visit our website: www.jharkhandaviation.in and submit the resume to e-mail: employment.jfi@gmail.com. Last date of receipt of application is-10.06.2026
Sd/-
(Managing Director)
Jharkhand Flying Institute
PR 380667 (Civil Aviation)26-27*D

SYMBOLIC POSSESSION NOTICE
ICICI Bank Branch Office: ICICI Bank Limited Plot No-23, Shal Tower, 3rd Floor, New Rohtak Road, Karol Bagh, New Delhi- 110005
The Authorised ICICI Bank Officer under the Securitisation, Reconstruction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act, 2002 and in exercise of the powers conferred under section 13(12) read with Rule 3 of the Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules 2002, issued Demand Notices to the borrower(s) mentioned below, to repay the amount mentioned in the Notice within 60 days from the date of receipt of the said Notice.
Having failed to repay the amount, the Notice is issued to the borrower and the public in general that the undersigned has taken symbolic possession of the property described below, by exercising powers conferred on him/her under Section 13(4) of the said Act read with Rule 8 of the said rules on the below-mentioned dates. The borrower in particular and the public in general are hereby cautioned not to deal with the property. Any dealings with the property will be subject to charges of ICICI Bank Limited.

Sr. No.	Name of the Borrower(s)/ Loan Account Number	Description of Property/ Date of Symbolic Possession	Date of Demand Notice/ Amount in Demand Notice (Rs)	Name of Branch
1.	Arvind Kumar/ Koshal Mishra/ LBGUR00004409300	Shop No G-070, Ground Floor, Rof Galleria, Sector 102, Gurgaon, Haryana- 122001, May 22, 2026	November 26, 2025 Rs. 22,11,880.81/-	Gurgaon (Haryana)
2.	Abhishek Aggarwal/ Rohit Aggarwal/ LBGUR00004287565	Flat No-1504, 15th Floor, Tower B, araville, Sector-79, Gurgaon- 122001, May 22, 2026	December 30, 2025 Rs. 2,55,28,015.37/-	Gurgaon (Haryana)/ Dehradun (Uttarakhand)/ Mumbai (Maharashtra)

The above-mentioned borrowers(s)/guarantors(s) is/are hereby issued a 30 day Notice to repay the amount, else the mortgaged properties will be sold after 30 days from the date of publishing this Notice, as per the provisions under Rules 8 and 9 of Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules 2002.
Date: May 26, 2026
Place: Gurgaon (Haryana)
Sincerely Authorised Officer For ICICI Bank Ltd.

World champ Gukesh admits criticism warranted

PARIS: D Gukesh refused to hide behind excuses, admitting that his form since winning the 2024 world title has fallen well below expectations and that criticism from former greats was justified.

Gukesh, who opens his Norway Chess campaign against Vincent Keymer, has endured an underwhelming past 18 months, struggling to secure top finishes as pressure mounts ahead of his world title defence later this year. Though the 19-year-old said he tries to block out the criticism, he admitted that results have not gone his way in the lead-up to his world title defence against challenger Javokhir Sindarov.

Carlsen cool about No.1 battle

OSLO: World No. 1 Magnus Carlsen sounded less dismissive than detached while reflecting on his gradual shift away from classical chess, making it clear that after more than a decade at the summit, his priorities have evolved even though his dominance has not faded.

The Norwegian great said that after conquering classical chess, he now derives greater joy from rapid and blitz, while

reminding the current generation that they must first climb the mountain he scaled and survive the unforgiving grind of elite classical battles before questioning his priorities.

Carlsen added that he now prefers a "steadier diet" of every format the game has to offer. "So there is at least some data to suggest that the rating that I have (in classical chess) now is fairly reasonable," said Carlsen.

"Most of it (critical comments made by former greats)

I don't see, but there are some that I have heard and I think it's

Man with midas touch

Brazil turn to Ancelotti to end long wait at WC

SAO PAULO: Brazil's biggest hope to end a 24-year World Cup title drought is not a clinical striker, a creative midfielder or a dribbling winger like in previous editions of the tournament. This time Brazilians are pinning their hopes on a 66-year-old Italian, who will be sitting on the bench.

Carlo Ancelotti, one of the most successful coaches of his generation, left Real Madrid to take over Brazil's national team last year, a rare example of a foreign coach in charge of the Seleção. Even though his results have been mixed — five wins, three losses and two draws — the country is optimistic he can elevate a squad which is seen as less star-studded than Brazil's iconic teams of the past, despite high-profile players like Neymar and Vinicius Júnior.

While Brazil has won the World Cup five times — more than any other team — it hasn't lifted the trophy since 2002, an eternity for a soccer-obsessed nation that produced some of the most brilliant players in history, such as Ronaldo, Ronaldinho and Pelé.



It seems Brazilians are generally satisfied with Carlo Ancelotti

Since 2002 it has only gotten beyond the quarterfinals once — as World Cup host in 2014 — and even that tournament ended in disappointment after an embarrassing 7-1 semifinal loss to eventual champion Germany.

Brazil's self-confidence hasn't been helped by the success of archrival Argentina, the defending World Cup champions and back-to-back Copa America winners. "It is allowed to believe," Ancelotti says in a World Cup-themed advertising campaign, acknowledging the self-doubt that has crawled into Brazil's

One of the biggest questions facing Ancelotti is what to do with 34-year-old Neymar

national soccer psyche. Brazil begin their World Cup campaign at MetLife stadium in New Jersey on June 13 against Morocco, semifinalist in the 2022 World Cup. Other Group C opponents are Haiti and Scotland.

Surviving the group stage is taken for granted in Brazil — anything else would be disaster in a World Cup expanded from 32 to 48 teams. How deep Brazil can go against stronger opponents in the knockout phase is less obvious.

"I am aware and reliant that this team can compete against the best in the world. Can we win the World Cup and reach the final? Yes, we can reach the final. But I don't know if that is enough, it is best for us to get there and win the final," Ancelotti said on May 18.



WAS NEVER IN THE RACE: IDRIS

Elba dismissed the rumours claiming he was considered for the role of the next James Bond

LOS ANGELES: Hollywood actor Idris Elba cleared the rumours claiming he was considered for the role of the next James Bond and said he was never in the race.

"Honestly, not in the race ever... My name's not getting thrown out, no way," he told entertainment news magazine 'People' in the interview.

The actor added, "They're going younger. And I wish them all the luck of the world. I can't wait - it's

going to be amazing."

Earlier this month, 'Amazon MGM Studios' officially began the search for the next James Bond, marking the start of casting. The studio has reportedly hired acclaimed casting director Nina Gold, known for her work on 'Game of Thrones', 'The Crown' and several 'Star Wars' films, to help find the successor to Daniel Craig.

'Amazon MGM' confirmed that casting is underway but declined to provide specific details, saying it will share updates when appropriate for fans of the franchise. The next instal-

ment, tentatively titled 'Bond 26', will be the first 'James Bond' film developed under 'Amazon MGM' following its acquisition of 'MGM Studios' and a later joint venture with longtime 'Bond' producers Barbara Broccoli and Michael G Wilson.

The creative team for the project is already in place. Denis Villeneuve, known for 'Dune', 'Dune: Part Two', 'Blade Runner 2049' and 'Arrival', will direct the film. The screenplay will be written by Steven Knight, creator of 'Peaky Blinders'. Producers include Amy Pascal and David Heyman, with Villeneuve's partner Tanya Lapointe serving as executive producer.

The 'Bond' franchise, which began in 1962, has previously been led by actors including Sean Connery, Roger Moore, Pierce Brosnan, Timothy Dalton and Daniel Craig across five films from 2006 to 2021.

Idris Elba will next feature in 'Masters of the Universe'. PTI



Denis Villeneuve, known for 'Dune', 'Dune: Part Two', 'Blade Runner 2049' and 'Arrival', will direct the film

Reunion on the set of 'Welcome to the Jungle'

OUR CORRESPONDENT

The multi-starrer 'Welcome to the Jungle' is all set to storm the theatres on June 26 and now, the makers have dropped the title track of the film, which has hit us with a major nostalgia for the 2007 'Welcome' era.

What makes the song even more special is the reunion of the original team behind the blockbuster 'Welcome' title track. After 19 long years, Akshay Kumar, singer Shaan, choreographer Ahmed Khan and producer Firoz Nadiadwala have come together once again for 'Welcome to the Jungle', recreating the same madness, energy and entertainment that audiences had fallen in love with years ago and now, choreographer-director Ahmed Khan is directing the film as well.

The newly released track perfectly captures the fun, chaos and larger-than-life vibe that made the original song such a cult favourite. Packed with vibrant visuals, high-energy per-



The multi-starrer is all set to storm the theatres on June 26

formances and catchy music and the mega starcast. The song features Akshay, Sunil Shetty, Raveena Tandon, Paresh Rawal, Arshad Warsi, Aftab Shivdasani, Disha Patani, Jacqueline Fernandez and more. Interestingly, we see Akshay in a double role in the song and he is expected to see in the film as well, which is another interesting fact about the film.

Khan, on the mega reunion, said, "Bringing back the 'Welcome' title track after 19 years was pure nostalgia for all of us. The moment Akshay, Firoz bhai and I came together again, it instantly reminded us of the madness and energy that made the original so iconic. But this time, the scale, cast and entertainment are much bigger. Since I am directing the film as well, I wanted the song to perfectly capture the wild, fun-filled world of 'Welcome to the Jungle'. It has chaos, humour, nostalgia and that larger-than-life vibe audiences love."

SOURAV GANGULY'S BIOPIC

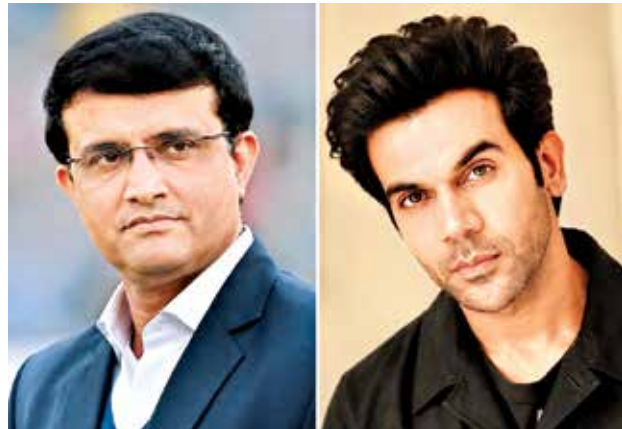
Shooting starts at ex-cricketer's Kolkata home

The much-anticipated biopic is tentatively titled 'Dada: The Sourav Ganguly Story'

OUR CORRESPONDENT

KOLKATA: After a few days of shooting in Mumbai, director Vikramaditya Motwane has started filming crucial scenes of Sourav Ganguly's biopic, tentatively titled 'Dada: The Sourav Ganguly Story', in Kolkata. Interestingly, on Monday, the cast and crew filmed important scenes at the former Indian cricket captain's house in Behala in south Kolkata. By now, we all know that Rajkumar Rao will be seen playing Sourav in the biopic.

Bengali actress Aparajita Auddy was seen in a white and red bordered saree, shooting for the much-awaited Bollywood movie. She will be seen as Nirupa Ganguly, Sourav's mother, in the film. On Monday, Motwane shot a sequence where a child actor,



The makers have reportedly cast Tanya Maniktala in the role of Dona Ganguly

who plays Sourav's growing-up years, was seen coming home. At the other end of his house, a little girl was seen keeping an eye on

him. Reportedly, this sequence shows the childhood love story of Sourav and his wife, dancer Dona Ganguly.

Meanwhile, Saswata Chatterjee, who will be seen as Sourav's father, Chandu Ganguly, reportedly shot a few sequences in Mumbai. Rahul Dev Bose will be seen playing Sourav's brother Snehasish Ganguly. The makers have reportedly cast Tanya Maniktala in the role of Dona Ganguly. Several names of Bengali actresses, like Mimi Chakraborty and Ishaa Saha, were doing the rounds.

Motwane will shoot for the biopic in various locations in Kolkata. In a recent podcast, Sourav praised Rao's acting skills and said that the movie will capture the journey of Indian cricket during his era.

THE PYRAMID SCHEME

A tale of ambition, greed & promise of quick money

OUR CORRESPONDENT

Prime Video' announced June 5 as the worldwide premiere date of its upcoming 'Prime Original' series 'The Pyramid Scheme'. Produced by 'The Viral Fever', created by Shreyansh Pandey, directed by Ashish R Shukla and Shreyansh Pandey, this drama explores the intriguing yet complex world of pyramid schemes and the dangerous lure of the quick money they promise.

The series features an ensemble cast with Paramvir Singh Cheema, Ranvir Shorey, Shekhar Suman, Aanjan Srivastava, Alfia Jafry and Ashish Raghava in the lead roles and supported by Akhileendra Mishra, Smita

Bansal, Vijay Kumar, Indresh Malik, Ravi Bhel, Sushant Singh, Sonal Jha and Sadanand Patil in pivotal roles.

'The Pyramid Scheme', set against the backdrop of culturally rich Haridwar, follows Goldy (Cheema), a charming and enterprising young man chasing a better life, who somehow finds himself pulled into the flashy, weirdly convincing world of pyramid marketing. As he joins hands with the grounded and deeply sincere Manoj Srivastava (Shorey), what begins as aspirations for a better life soon spirals into something darker, driven by greed, ambition and betrayal.

"At 'Prime Video', we remain committed to championing authentic, emotionally reso-



licensing, 'Prime Video, India'. "What makes this series compelling is the way it brings to life the relatable themes of ambition and aspiration and how the pursuit of a better life can influence one's choices, both good and bad. Led by standout performances from Paramvir Singh Cheema, along with Ranvir Shorey and Shekhar Suman in striking new avatars, the narrative balances humour, drama and emotions with authenticity and emotional depth."

Vijay Koshi, the president of 'The Viral Fever' (TVF), shared, "With this series, we wanted to explore ambition, validation and the world of pyramid schemes, something not really shown on screen."

nant stories that reflect the diverse voices and aspirations of India. Our upcoming drama 'The Pyramid Scheme' exemplifies this," said Manish Menghani, director & head of content

WITH LAUGHTER, QUESTIONS & MEMORABLE CHARACTERS

The golden era of entertainment returns on Doordarshan National

The new programming lineup will present a perfect blend of comedy, social relevance and knowledge

OUR CORRESPONDENT

India's prestigious public broadcaster is once again bringing an exciting lineup of programs filled with entertainment, knowledge and family values for its viewers. 'Doordarshan National' will now offer wholesome entertainment that connects every generation and gives families an opportunity to come together and enjoy television viewing.

The new programming lineup on 'Doordarshan National' will present a perfect blend of comedy, social relevance and knowledge. With the return of popular shows, the channel aims to revive cherished memories for viewers while also delivering a fresh entertainment experience for the new generation.

The biggest highlight will be the country's most popular and evergreen quiz show, the evergreen

'Kaun Banega Crorepati' (KBC), which isn't merely a quiz show but a platform representing the hopes, dreams and inspiring stories of millions of Indians. Over the years, the program has established itself as one of Indian television's most trusted and popular knowledge-based shows. The legendary host Amitabh Bachchan's powerful presentation, engaging conversations and emotional connection with participants make the show special for viewers of all age groups.

KBC has given ordinary people from across the country a new identity through their talent and knowledge. The show not only entertains but also inspires audiences, enhances general knowledge and boosts confidence. Every episode brings together excitement, emotions, inspiring struggles and the power of knowledge. The journeys of contestants and their efforts to fulfil their dreams deeply connect



with viewers. The questions asked in the show are based on Indian culture, history, sports, science, cinema and current affairs, making it a complete family entertain-

ment program. With its iconic style, engaging questions and inspiring atmosphere, it's all set to return with the same excitement and enthusiasm among viewers. The show will

air Monday to Friday at 9 pm exclusively on 'Doordarshan National'.

In addition, viewers will also get to watch the evergreen drama series 'Rajni 2.0'. Set in a contemporary backdrop and centred around a strong female protagonist, the show will effectively highlight various social issues. It tells the story of a courageous and intelligent woman who faces challenges with determination and confidence. The show promises a compelling mix of social awareness and family emotions. Its engaging storytelling, attractive visuals and powerful presentation will keep viewers connected with every episode. The program will air Monday to Friday at 8 pm.

For audiences who enjoy comedy and satire, 'Office Office: Chali Musaddi Ki Beti' will bring a unique blend of humour and social commentary. Carrying forward the legacy of the popular show 'Office

The biggest highlight will be the country's most popular and evergreen quiz show, 'Kaun Banega Crorepati' (KBC)

Office', this new version portrays the daily struggles of the common man in a light-hearted yet impactful manner. The show attempts to deliver meaningful social messages that will not only entertain viewers but also encourage them to reflect on societal realities. Interesting characters, witty dialogues and contemporary themes make the

program appealing to audiences across all age groups. The show will air Monday to Friday at 8:30 pm.

Viewers will also be able to enjoy all these programs on the 'Waves OTT' platform. Keeping the needs of modern digital audiences in mind, it will provide viewers with the flexibility to watch their favourite programs anytime and anywhere. Available across multiple digital platforms, including mobile phones, tablets and smart TVs, the platform will offer a seamless and convenient entertainment experience.

'Doordarshan National' has always been a symbol of Indian culture, family values and quality entertainment. Through these new offerings, the channel aims to provide meaningful content that not only entertains but also delivers positive and inspiring messages for audiences of every age group.